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POWERLIST 2023

CORPORATE VENTURING LEADERS SHAPING THE FUTURE OF THE INDUSTRY

If your name's not on the list, there's a good reason why



Maija Palmer
Editor

So what is different in Powerlist 2023? Well, I have to warn you: this Powerlist is unauthorised. I say this with pride. There are corporate venture units on this list that did not necessarily want to be there and there are units that wanted to be included that are not. You do not pay – cannot pay – to be on this list. And you cannot pay to be taken off.

It is important to know that this list is independent. It is chosen by the Global Corporate Venturing editorial team, a group of people who spend every day looking at the CVC activity around the world, analysing monthly, quarterly and annual data on who is investing, who is not, sectors that are taking off, trends in deal sizes. We interview hundreds of CVC professionals every year for our podcast, videos and website.

Is the list perfect? I doubt it. But you would be hard-pressed to find a more accurate or independent one for the corporate venturing industry.

I also want to tell you that the Powerlist will evolve. We already chose, this year, not to rank corporate investors. I believe it is impossible to compare very different

corporate investment units in any meaningful way. Some units aim to make just three, highly strategic investments each year. Others take a dozen smaller bets. Which one of these is more “powerful”?

We chose entries this year to highlight not just CVC leaders with many deals or a great run with exits, but those that are taking unique approaches to corporate venture. The longer entries in this publication are designed to showcase some of those ideas. And, although there are some names here – such as Paul Asel, Stefan Gabriel and Bill Taranto – who have been regulars on the Powerlist since it began in 2012, we have also deliberately sought new entrants.

Next year, we plan to go further in turning The List into a display of effective corporate venturing practice across maturity phases and sectors. We are hoping this will become more of an educational tool for corporate venturing professionals rather than a list of biographies.

If your unit is doing something interesting, we would love to talk to you about potential inclusion in next year's List.

But you still will not be able to buy your way in. ■



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SELECTION PROCESS

The Global Corporate Venturing Powerlist represents the 100 individuals who we feel are spearheading the future of the corporate venturing industry. The list is selected by the Global Corporate Venturing editorial team based on a performance over the past 12 months on a number of criteria.

One factor is a simple numerical look at the number of deals and exits that a particular corporate venturing team has achieved, and you will find some Powerlist winners who are prolific dealmakers. Investors who back startups in order to build an ecosystem around their platform – such as Salesforce or blockchain company Coinbase – participate in an exceptionally large number of funding rounds each year.

Numbers are not everything, though. Some investors only have a remit to make a handful of deals a year. So, we also look at factors such as the success of the unit and the clarity of the approach to corporate venturing. We also look at CVC leaders who are particularly active in helping develop the next generation

of corporate investors and who have done foundational work in professionalising this industry.

Many investors on this list are veterans with easy-to-see track records. We have, however, also made a point of looking for new names. Around 20% of the people on this list are newcomers. Some of them may not yet have a similar record to point to, but we have opted to include them because we felt they represented a fresh approach worth watching. We have also been keen to highlight investors from emerging regions, for example, Mukaya Panich, of SBC 10X, based in Thailand, and Donald Wihardja, of MDI Ventures, based in Indonesia.

As much as possible, in each entry, particularly in the longer ones, we have sought to explain and showcase why these are individuals and units worth watching.

POWERLIST 2024

If you have any suggestions for Powerlist 2024, please get in touch, we would value your input.

About Global Corporate Venturing

I would like to thank the GCV editorial team: Kim Moore, Rob Lavine, Fernando Moncada Rivera, Roshini Bains, Edison Fu and Kaloyan Andonov for all their hard work, as well as profile writer Chris Torney, and Salvatore Spagnuolo for design and production. Without them we could not have made this happen.

Global Corporate Venturing aims to connect corporate venturers with everything they need to excel in their roles, including the GCV Leadership Society, courses at the GCV Institute, the GCV Keystone benchmarking service, conferences and regional meetups and our news site: www.globalventuring.com. If you would like any further information about these, please let us know.



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Jim Adler

Founder and general partner **Toyota Ventures**



We have been on an exciting journey with our portfolio companies to discover what is next for Toyota and the planet

Jim Adler founded Toyota Ventures, Japanese carmaker Toyota's first standalone early-stage venture capital firm, in July 2017. The team invests in artificial intelligence, autonomy, mobility, robotics, cloud technology, smart cities, digital health, fintech and materials through the Toyota Ventures Frontier Fund. It also invests in startups that are creating scalable solutions for carbon neutrality, as part of the Toyota Ventures Climate Fund.

In recent months, the San Francisco-headquartered firm announced its participation in the series A rounds for Starfish Space, a developer of in-orbit servicing vehicles, and insect protein company Future Fields. Toyota Ventures also announced the addition of battery control technology firm Relectrify, carbon removal biotechnology startup Living Carbon and Syzygy Plasmonics, a developer

of all-electric photocatalytic reactors, to its portfolio – bringing it to a total of 68 companies.

“Startups are not small versions of big companies. They are stem cells that evolve to succeed,” says Adler. “Since we started our first fund six years ago, we have been on an exciting journey with our portfolio companies to discover what is next for Toyota and the planet.”

Before founding Toyota Ventures, Adler joined Toyota subsidiary Toyota Research Institute in 2016, where he served as VP of data and business development. Prior to that, he was VP of products and marketing at Metanautix, a big data analytics startup funded by Sequoia Capital and Workday that was acquired by Microsoft.

He received a bachelor's degree in electrical engineering from the University of Florida, and a master's in electrical and computer engineering from the University of California, San Diego. ■

Kitty Agarwal

Partner **Info Edge Ventures**



Agarwal has played an important role in driving the company's involvement in the Indian startup ecosystem

Kitty Agarwal is a partner at Info Edge Ventures, a corporate venture capital arm launched by Info Edge, in early 2020. As part of her role, Agarwal leads the unit's investments in early-stage consumer technology companies, primarily focusing on seed and series A-stage deals.

The unit is backed by Singaporean sovereign wealth fund Temasek and runs three funds: Info Edge Venture Fund, Info Edge Capital and Capital 2B.

Info Edge committed an initial investment of Rs 1bn (\$14m) in January 2020. The CVC fund, called Info Edge Venture Fund (IEVF), raised an additional Rs 3.8bn for its first fund in December 2020, with Temasek as the primary investor. IEVF is focused on backing early-stage rounds for consumer technology startups, which complements Info Edge's existing businesses.

In recent months, Info Edge has invested

in companies such as pet care products and services provider Sploot, agricultural yield data software provider Gramophone and online chemical marketplace Elchemy.

Info Edge also scored an exit in March 2023 when social commerce platform Bulbulive Shopping Network was acquired by The Good Glamm Group for an undisclosed amount.

Before joining Info Edge Ventures, Agarwal served in various capacities at Info Edge, including as associate VP for two years from 2016 and head of corporate development for a year. During this time, she oversaw investments in companies such as Zomato, Canvera Digital Technologies, ETechAces, Happily Unmarried (Ustara) and Meritnation (Applect Learning Systems).

Since joining the firm, Agarwal has played an important role in driving the company's involvement in the Indian startup ecosystem. ■

Shan Aggarwal

VP and head of corporate development **Coinbase Ventures**

Shan Aggarwal heads up Coinbase Ventures, one of the most active corporate VC units by deal count. Over Aggarwal's five-year tenure, Coinbase Ventures has 339 active portfolio companies and 15 exits.

Coinbase Ventures invests in founders who share Coinbase's mission of creating more economic freedom for the world. In practice, this means the unit invests in crypto and web3 startups, covering everything from metaverse and non-fungible tokens (NFTs) to decentralised finance, gaming finance and developer tools.

Its portfolio includes NFT marketplace OpenSea, cryptocurrency tax service TaxBit, and FalconX, an institutional crypto trading platform. Since the beginning of this year, while other crypto CVCs have slowed down or disappeared entirely, Coinbase has continued to invest, funding companies such as trading

infrastructure platform Architect, and restaking protocol EigenLayer. Recent deals include backing decentralised exchange protocol Dolomite, cryptocurrency trading infrastructure company zkLink and decentralised finance protocol developer DFlow.

In addition to venture investments, Aggarwal has led Coinbase's global M&A efforts, including the acquisition of companies such as crypto brokerage Tagomi and crypto asset management company One River Digital.

Prior to joining Coinbase, Aggarwal spent three years as an investor at Greycroft, focusing on mobile and internet-based startups across fintech and media. He previously helped found undergraduate-focused consulting firm Bruin Consulting, before heading to Bain & Company for a two-year stint as an associate consultant. ■



Over Aggarwal's five-year tenure, Coinbase Ventures has completed more than 300 investments

Mahdi Aladel

CEO **Aramco Ventures**

Mahdi Aladel has been CEO of Aramco Ventures, the corporate venturing unit of the world's largest oil and gas company, Saudi Aramco, since taking over from Majid Mufti in 2020.

Aladel was a corporate strategist at Aramco before leaving the role in August 2013 to help enable the transformation of Motiva Enterprises in Houston, Texas, which at the time was a joint venture between Aramco and Shell. He rejoined Aramco in late 2017 as the director of the base oils and lubricants department, in which he founded and led Aramco's Global Base Oils Alliance and the development of the Aramco lubricants business and brand.

Aramco Ventures was set up in 2012 as a \$500m evergreen programme with a mandate to invest in technologies that could bring value to its parent. Early investments were mainly in core oil and gas tech, although in recent years

the unit's major focus has shifted to IR4.0 (the fourth industrial revolution), digital and sustainability technologies.

Aramco Ventures has also launched two \$1bn-plus funds: Prosperity7 Ventures and the Sustainability Fund. Saudi Aramco supplied capital for both. Launched in 2019, Prosperity7 is structured like a traditional venture capital fund, focused on deeptech from the US and China. The Sustainability Fund was set up in 2022 to support the decarbonisation of Saudi Aramco's own operations and to help the company develop new lower-carbon fuels businesses, such as hydrogen, ammonia and synthetic fuels.

In recent months, Aramco Ventures has taken part in the \$139m series B round for clean energy developer Amogy, as well as the \$15m series A raise for HT Materials Science, a developer of nanofluid technology. ■



In recent years the unit's major focus has shifted to IR4.0 (the fourth industrial revolution), digital and sustainability technologies

Lak Ananth

CEO and managing partner **Next47**



Ananth has concentrated on identifying industry-changing disruptions and acting on them as an investor

Lak Ananth became chief executive and managing partner of Next47, the US-based corporate venturing arm of Germany-headquartered industrial conglomerate Siemens, when the unit was formed in October 2016.

Ananth began his career as an engineer working with startups during the dotcom boom at the turn of the millennium, and has since concentrated on identifying industry-changing disruptions and acting on them as an investor or acquirer. At Next47, his investment focus is on applications of artificial intelligence and machine learning, as well as vertical software-as-a-service, enterprise IT, robotics, mobility and other emerging areas of deeptech.

Next47 has invested in more than 160 businesses developing deep technologies including augmented and virtual reality, cybersecurity, autonomous transportation, the

internet of things, advanced manufacturing and automation. To date, it has achieved 70 exits. Over the past 12 months, the unit led customer success platform Vitally's \$30m series B round and also provided funding for Skydio, a drone technology manufacturer, and Locus Robotics, among others.

Prior to joining Next47, Ananth founded and built Hewlett Packard Pathfinder, the corporate venturing arm of computing technology producer Hewlett Packard Enterprise (HPE), bringing together venture investing and revenue-generating business development for portfolio companies from HPE customers. He also previously worked in strategy at networking equipment supplier Cisco Systems.

Ananth has an MBA from Insead and the Wharton School of Business, an MS from Kansas State University and a BE from Guindy Engineering College, India. ■

Nanna Andersen

Head of new growth and ventures **H&M Group**



Andersen spent a year running Swedish health education startup Inspirata/Svenska Hälsocampen

Nanna Andersen is the head of new growth and ventures at H&M Group, the Sweden-based fashion retailer. She joined H&M in 2016 as an investment manager and business developer at the corporate's investment arm, H&M Co:Lab and New Business, before taking over as lead at the unit's successor, H&M Group Ventures, a year later.

H&M invests in three main areas: sustainable fashion startups that are developing the technologies needed for the fashion industry to become less environmentally harmful, new retail companies that are exploring the consumer behaviours and entrepreneurs creating tools to improve retail efficiency and customer service.

Andersen has led investments in companies including Klarna, the buy-now-pay-later company, second-hand marketplace Sellpy (which H&M later acquired), lifestyle brand

Goop, logistics technology company Budbee and Sheertex, the snag-proof tights producer. She co-led investments in textile recycling company Renewcell and Smartex.AI, which is developing computer vision that can detect defects in garments.

The unit, which has 25 active portfolio companies, has recently invested in an \$8.7m seed round for deeptech startup Rubi Laboratories, which is developing a way to convert carbon emissions into a cellulose fibre that can be used for textile manufacturing. H&M also led an \$8m series A funding round for Kintra, which is developing a biodegradable polyester.

Andersen started in real estate investment, with several years as an investor at Sweden's Gabriellsson Invest. She also spent a year as an entrepreneur, running Swedish health education startup Inspirata/Svenska Hälsocampen. ■

Paul Asel

>FEATUREDENTRY

Co-founder and managing partner **NGP Capital**

When Paul Asel co-founded NGP Capital, the venture capital firm backed by Nokia, in 2005, Nokia was by far the most dominant handset maker in the market and the whole telecoms sector looked very different from how it is today.

Just two years later in 2007, as NGP closed its second investment fund, a period of profound change began: Apple's iPhone debuted in June that year starting a process that would see Nokia's handset market recede rapidly.

The close relationship between Nokia and NGP was tested by these changes. Around 85% of the startups that NGP's second fund invested in started with partnerships with a Nokia business unit. However, as Nokia sold off its flagship handset business and switched its focus to mobile networking, this strategic alignment changed. By 2016 only 10% of the portfolio was relevant to the restructured Nokia business.

Yet out of challenging circumstances, the \$250m fund delivered top quartile results, creating six unicorns and seven public companies from its 28 investments. Some of its biggest successes included the IPO of Pubmatic, an advertising software company that listed on Nasdaq with a first-day valuation of more than \$1.4bn in 2020.

NGP Capital was also an investor in Deliveroo, the food delivery business that was valued at £7.6bn when it listed on the London Stock Exchange in 2021.

As well as bringing in the financial returns, NGP was also instrumental in being an early-warning signal to Nokia, says Asel, alerting the company, for example, to the shift to Android phones, and helping to broker deals in China, which remained a strong market for Nokia longer than many other regions.

Asel believes that corporate investing must be both strategic and financial.

"Our 'financial-first-but-not-financial-only' strategy has stood the test of time amid significant corporate change. This strategy

recognises that startups must do well to do good: they must perform well financially to have a material strategic impact," he says.

Nokia has continued to back new funds for NGP, most recently a \$400m commitment in 2022 which brought the firm's total assets under management to \$1.6bn. The 29-person team, with offices in Europe, Silicon Valley and China, continues to work closely with Nokia.

Its focus is investing in technologies that are bringing the physical and virtual worlds together: everything from mobile sensor to cloud services. NGP is also interested in technologies such as automated manufacturing, robotics and automated vehicles, which will be enabled by the arrival of 5G network connectivity.

Recent investments include leading the \$65m series B funding round for Akeyless, a developer of software that helps keep corporate data secret. It also backed the \$40m fundraising for Shippeo, a French software-as-a-service company that helps companies manage their supply chains.

"We believe NGP V promises to be a good vintage as valuations improve much as they had for NGP II in 2007. This is a great time to start new businesses as entrepreneurs can focus on building companies with lower capital requirements, less dilution and fewer me-too competitors," says Asel.

Asel has more than 25 years of experience in startup investing. Before co-founding NGP Capital, he led technology investments in Southeast Asia for the International Finance Corporation. Before that, he was a partner at investment firm Telos Venture Partners, headed M&A at Cadence Design Systems, a design automation company, and worked in wealth management at Merrill Lynch.

Asel holds an MBA from Stanford University, as well as a degree from Dartmouth College. ■



This is a great time to start new businesses as entrepreneurs can focus on building companies with lower capital requirements, less dilution and fewer me-too competitors

Minas Apelian

VP of internal and external venturing **Nova by Saint-Gobain**



When sourcing investment opportunities, Nova seeks traits that can support or improve its core business

Minas Apelian is the vice president of internal and external venturing at Nova by Saint-Gobain, the strategic investment arm of Paris-listed advanced materials producer Saint-Gobain. He has led Saint-Gobain's external and internal ventures teams to help drive the firm's innovation strategy since 2013.

Formed in 2006, Nova seeks startups developing technologies, services and products that align with its parent's focus on sustainability and well-being, and offers the corporate's resources and know-how to entrepreneurs.

Nova has a team of 14 based around the world, with representatives in the US, France, the Netherlands and China. The unit studies approximately 1,000 startups a year, half of which are examined in greater depth before 100 are selected to be evaluated alongside

Saint-Gobain's various business units to identify potential strategic alignment.

When sourcing investment opportunities, Nova seeks traits that can support or improve its core business, such as technologies or products that can enhance the construction value chain, or innovations that enable the development of more efficient building spaces.

In February 2023, the unit participated in the \$7m seed round for Enteligent, a solar power company, while in December 2022 it backed sound technology developer Treble in a \$6m seed round. Other recent investments include data-acquisition firm Newboot and Utility Global, a developer of energy-storage solutions.

Apelian holds a PhD in chemical engineering from Massachusetts Institute of Technology. ■

Roy Bahat

Head **Bloomberg Beta**



Bahat emphasises the importance of building trust between his team and the founders they support

Roy Bahat has been head of Bloomberg Beta, a venture capital firm backed solely by media company Bloomberg, for more than a decade. Bloomberg Beta is currently investing from its fourth \$75m seed fund with a focus on the future of work and machine intelligence.

Since being set up in 2013, Bloomberg Beta has made more than 260 investments and has realised 34 exits, with a total of \$375m currently under management. The unit backs companies regardless of whether they have, or intend to have, a business relationship with its parent.

In recent months, Bloomberg Beta has invested in analytics platform Savant Labs, business video tool company Capsule and Poly, a firm which develops software to use artificial intelligence to generate design assets.

Bahat has described Bloomberg itself as 'one of the original technology startups', with an

ethos that has been carried on into its corporate venturing unit. He emphasises the importance of building trust between his team and the founders they support. Unusually, Bloomberg Beta has published its operating manual as open-source software and this includes a detailed explanation of what the unit looks for in investee companies.

Prior to Bloomberg Beta, Bahat was founder and chairman of gaming console company Ouya, which was sold to Razer in 2015. He was previously president of IGN Entertainment and vice president at media group News Corporation. He was also director of strategy for NYC2012, the ultimately unsuccessful bid by New York City to host the 2012 Olympic Games.

Bahat has a master of philosophy in economics from Oxford University and read social studies at Harvard University. ■

John Banta

President and managing director **Blue Venture Fund**

John Banta is president and managing director of the Blue Venture Fund, a corporate venture capital unit with more than \$1bn under management across four funds sponsored by the Blue Cross Blue Shield Association, a federation of 36 US health insurance organisations.

Banta has been with the unit since 2014 and is responsible for maintaining relationships with all stakeholders to ensure the operational success of the fund, as well as the generation of a strategic and financial return.

Blue Venture Fund makes investments that align with the long-term goals of its sponsors. Investments are stage-agnostic and typically range from \$1m-\$20m. Among the unit's recent investments are digital health specialist Limber and mental health service Fort Health.

Speaking to Global Corporate Venturing earlier in 2023, Banta said that the previous

12 months had been 'incredibly productive' for Blue Venture Fund, despite wider market difficulties. He added: "The challenges that persist in healthcare markets are profound, and entrepreneurs that are addressing them creatively merit, and continue to attract, support. Enterprise players also remain active in acquiring market-tested and proven innovation, which is very helpful for us."

From 2002 to 2014, Banta was chief executive and managing director of Illinois Ventures, an early-stage technology investment firm launched by University of Illinois and focused on companies deriving from Midwest universities and labs.

Banta has an MBA in finance and statistics from the University of Chicago Graduate School of Business and a bachelor's degree in finance from the University of Illinois. ■



Entrepreneurs that are creatively addressing the challenges in the healthcare markets merit, and continue to attract, support

Marcus Behrendt

Managing director **BMW i Ventures**

Marcus Behrendt has been managing director of BMW i Ventures, the US-based venture capital firm formed by Germany-headquartered automotive manufacturer BMW, since August 2022, having previously served as the unit's CEO.

Launched by its parent in 2016, BMW i Ventures has accumulated a portfolio of more than 50 companies. Among its most notable exits are Chargepoint, the vehicle charging network, and manufacturing services marketplace Xometry, which floated in a \$302m IPO in 2021.

In 2021, the unit launched a \$300m fund focusing on sustainability and operating alongside BMW i Ventures' \$500m first fund. The sustainability fund targets early and mid-stage companies concentrating on sustainability, transportation, manufacturing and supply chain technologies. Behrendt

and his colleague Kasper Sage were named managing partners.

At the time, Behrendt said: "With Fund II we will refocus our investment thesis to even better serve the needs of the ecosystem and the BMW Group as a whole. Even more than before, circularity and sustainability will play a key role in our investment activities."

Among the unit's recent investments are a lead role on the €15m series A round for drive unit developer Deep Drive, as well as involvement in the €50m series C raise for Plus One Robotics, a logistics automation business.

Behrendt joined BMW i Ventures in 2018 having worked for the parent company in its user experience and concept quality divisions. Previous roles include CEO of automotive industry consultant JD Power Europe and a stint at motor manufacturer Mercedes-Benz. ■



We will refocus our investment thesis to even better serve the needs of the ecosystem and the BMW Group as a whole

Amy Belt Raimundo

Managing director **Kaiser Permanente Ventures**



Amy Belt Raimundo is the managing director at Kaiser Permanente Ventures, the corporate venturing arm of US-based healthcare provider Kaiser Permanente.

Founded in 1997, Kaiser Permanente Ventures has invested in and helped support about 65 companies, representing innovations in healthcare delivery over the past 25 years. Its mission is to leverage the insights that come from those leading Kaiser Permanente's healthcare systems and care delivery to identify the most pressing needs in healthcare – and select the innovations that most effectively address those opportunities.

Kaiser Permanente Ventures' most recent deals include a role in the \$80m series B round for Incredible Health, a recruitment platform for medical professionals. Among its exits are Health Catalyst, a health data analytics platform

which listed on the Nasdaq exchange in 2019, and mental-health support service Ginger, which was acquired by digital health platform Headspace in 2021.

Belt Raimundo joined Kaiser Permanente Ventures as managing director in 2016. Before joining the investment unit, Belt Raimundo was the chief business officer of digital health startup Evidation Health. She has led investments or held board roles in more than 15 healthcare companies across digital health, healthcare IT, diagnostics and medical devices.

Earlier in her career, she held operating roles at Guidant Corporation. She began her career as a management consultant for hospitals at APM/CSC Healthcare.

Belt Raimundo has an MBA from the University of California at Berkeley. ■



Belt Raimundo has led investments or held board roles in more than 15 healthcare companies

Paul Bernard

Director of worldwide corporate development **Amazon Alexa Fund**



Amazon's Alexa Fund is US-based ecommerce, cloud and internet technology group Amazon's corporate venturing fund, which was set up in 2015. Dedicated to finding and supporting startups that work with voice technology, it has invested in businesses in areas such as AI, connected homes and healthtech services.

The Alexa Fund has made 130 investments and achieved 21 exits. "Our goal is to identify startups creating new experiences with Alexa or advancing the state-of-the-art in voice technology and to give them the resources they need to grow their business," says Paul Bernard, who leads the fund.

The Alexa Fund has \$200m under management and focuses on voice technology innovation that is compatible with Alexa voice recognition systems. The team believes human voice-enabled devices will boost the way

users interact with technology. In addition to funding, the fund supports entrepreneurs to transform their innovative ideas into products and services.

Recent deals involving the fund include a lead role in the \$20m series A round for metaverse-based entertainment company Superplastic, as well as participation in the \$60m series A raise for Osmo, a startup that develops technology enabling computers to analyse and synthesise specific smells. It also joined the \$42m series B round for robotics company Scythe.

Bernard has worked for Amazon since 2013. Prior to this, he was the director for worldwide corporate development. He previously worked for mobile phone manufacturer Nokia for more than 12 years. Bernard has a master's degree in management from the Kellogg School of Management at Northwestern University. ■



Our goal is to identify startups creating new experiences with Alexa or advancing the state-of-the-art in voice technology

Brendon Blacker

Managing partner **Delivery Hero Ventures**

Brendon Blacker has been in charge of Delivery Hero Ventures, the independently managed venture capital fund backed by food technology company Delivery Hero, since it was set up in January 2021.

The unit, which operated under the name DX Ventures until adopting its current name last year, aims to “support the next generation of disruptive, founder-led technology companies to achieve long-term success”.

Discussing the March 2022 rebrand, Blacker said: “By adopting this new brand identity, Delivery Hero Ventures is highlighting a key part of its value proposition: our ability to leverage Delivery Hero’s unique ecosystem to benefit our founders and help them grow world-leading businesses.”

Among the unit’s first wave of portfolio

investments were companies such as social commerce platform Facily; Southeast Asian chain Flash Coffee; Toku, a cloud communications business; and Olio, a mobile app designed to reduce food waste. More recently, the unit participated in the \$16m series B round for Yodawy, an online pharmacy marketplace and insurance benefits manager, as well as the \$3m seed round for Egypt-based food importer OneOrder. The unit has been involved in 20 investment rounds since it was formed.

Before joining Delivery Hero Ventures, Blacker spent more than 13 years as senior vice president of Macquarie Group, leading the company’s venture capital investments in consumer internet, enterprise software and fintech businesses in Asia, Australia and Europe. ■



We support the next generation of disruptive, founder-led technology companies to achieve long-term success

Kenneth Bronfin

Senior managing director **Hearst Ventures**

Media group Hearst Corporation has been a stalwart of corporate venturing for more than two decades. Its venturing unit has made more than \$1bn in strategic investments in startups operating at the intersection of media and technology, and its portfolio currently stands at more than 50 companies.

As an early adopter of corporate venturing, Hearst Ventures can lay claim to starting its investment programme as one of five corporate investors in Netscape, the US-based search engine widely credited for kick-starting the dotcom boom after the success of its IPO in 1995.

Kenneth Bronfin has been the senior managing director of Hearst Ventures since 2013, having previously worked as president and group head of Hearst Interactive Media for more than 10 years. Hearst Ventures has offices in London, Tel Aviv and Beijing, in

addition to its headquarters in New York City.

Publicly listed set-top streaming device producer Roku, online news pioneer BuzzFeed and mobility operations unicorn Via were among the unit’s investments over the past decade.

Recent deals include roles in a \$2m venture round for Aiir Innovations, a Netherlands-based developer of AI technology for use in borescope inspections, and a \$55m series E round for drone-based analytics business Zeitview. Hearst Ventures also led the \$12m seed round for Caramel, a motor vehicle sales platform.

Bronfin also advises Hearst business units on their individual digital and M&A strategies. He has been with Hearst since 1996, having previously worked as general manager of television network NBC’s digital television group. He has an MBA from the Wharton School at the University of Pennsylvania. ■



Its venturing unit has made more than \$1bn in strategic investments in startups in media and technology

Chad Bown

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Managing director **BP Ventures**



Chad Bown is a managing director at BP Ventures, the corporate venture arm of the UK oil and gas major. The unit has invested more than \$1bn in more than 70 startups since its inception in 2006.

A former captain with the US Air Force, Bown worked at Shell and Jacobs Engineering before joining BP in 2011.

BP Ventures focuses on investments in private, high-growth businesses aiming to accelerate innovation across BP's transition growth engines: renewables and power trading, EV charging, convenience, bioenergy and hydrogen, as well as carbon capture and storage.

Bown describes the unit's portfolio management style as "engaged". Team members take either board or observer seats depending on the startups' needs.

He sees the team's role as providing a platform for startups to test and develop their product, as well as a way to introduce portfolio companies to its customers. "We are not just bringing money and capital, we are trying to help incubate the technology, pilot it and commercialise it. We want to make sure they have a multitude of industry customers, not just BP."

The recent financial market uncertainty has meant the unit's focus continues to be on helping startups with cash conservation. "We are looking at how we can extend the cash runway. We try to find ways to get product out to market sooner, so it is not just a cash-hungry business, that they are also making revenue," says Bown.

To keep the team advancing, ventures team members get their feet wet with all aspects of investing, says Bown. "A lot is on-the-job training. We want to move people around, which build on their strengths, getting them exposed to diverse sectors and different products."

He makes a point of hiring team members internally who may not know all aspects of venture capital. He also hires people externally who have worked in venture capital but have limited experience of CVC. "There are a lot of individuals working in

financial VC who want to get into corporate VC. We also want people who are excited about the energy transition."

BP Ventures hired Gareth Burns to head the unit in January 2023 following his successful tenure at Equinor. Burns replaces Meghan Sharp who is now the global head of Decarbonization Partners, a financial VC of a joint venture between Blackrock and Temasek.

Bown lists several recent new and follow-on investments which he expects will bring value to BP, including 5B, an Australian distributed solar company; Magenta Mobility, an Indian e-mobility business; and Oxbotica, an autonomous vehicle software company.

Other investments include UK-based Silicon Microgravity, a sensor technology for flood monitoring and control; Saltworks Technologies, a developer and manufacturer of solutions for desalination and chemical recovery; and BiSN, a plugging solution based on deploying a liquified metal alloy into holes to plug leaks and control water or gas production; and Fulcrum Energy, a manufacturer of biojet fuel from waste.

Since it was launched, the unit has invested \$500m in technology companies. It has partnered with 40 startups and worked with 200 co-investors. The portfolio has also had nine exits.

The investment unit also focuses on digital technologies. Examples are blockchain technology, artificial intelligence and cognitive computing. An example is its investment in Beyond Limits, an artificial intelligence and cognitive computing company, which has helped the company improve the speed and quality of decision making and manage operational risks.

Bown has a degree in business from Texas A&M University, as well as an MBA from Loyola Marymount University.

He currently sits on the boards of Xpanisiv, Eavor Technology, Beyond Limits and BiSN. ■



There are a lot of individuals working in financial VC who want to get into corporate VC. We also want people who are excited about the energy transition

Debra Brackeen

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Chief strategy and innovation officer **CSAA Insurance Group**

When Debra Brackeen took the helm as CSAA Insurance Group's chief strategy and innovation officer in 2016, she was handed a huge target – to create \$1bn in new lines of revenue for the more than 100-year-old home and auto insurance company within a decade. It was a time when the auto market appeared to be facing imminent disruption from trends like ride hailing, car sharing and even autonomous driving.

CSAA, which was founded in 1914, only a few years after the Model-T Ford had started to create a mass automobile market, was asking itself what car insurance would look like in a world where fewer people would own or drive their own vehicle.

"The CEO and board said 'we need to place some bets' and that was why my role was created. My task was to work with the leadership team to identify new markets where we wanted to play in the future," says Brackeen.

Brackeen knew that creating \$1bn in new revenues lines would not be possible solely through investment in startups. It would require what she refers to as "the whole toolkit" of corporate innovation – accelerator programmes for very young companies, investment in industry-disrupting startups, evaluating emerging tech in the lab and even getting CSAA to build its own startups internally.

The first of these internally built ventures was Mobilitas Insurance, which provides custom-built solutions for the sharing economy and mobility sectors. This business is well on its way towards that \$1bn goal.

The company's venture capital arm, Avanta Ventures, was formed in 2017 to target disruptive mobility technology startups and has more than \$300m under management after launching a second fund in September 2022. It invests between \$1m and \$10m per deal, mainly in seed to series B funding rounds. It has a portfolio of 17 startups, including Delos, a developer of new ways of calculating the risk of forest fires, which Avanta has backed since seed stage.

The unit has also backed RapidSOS, the operator of a service that links mobile devices to first responders in emergency situations, and Car IQ, a California-based startup that is developing digital payment solutions that can be linked to cars, so that drivers can pay for fuel, toll charges or parking directly through their vehicle. Its scope has also expanded, to take in areas such as financial, cybersecurity, smart home and applied artificial intelligence technology.

"We are not investing solely for financial returns; our primary measure is strategic value. We invest in really good companies relevant to our long-term strategy, and we try to partner with them to create some form of commercial value," says Brackeen.

She has a very long track-record in Silicon Valley tech, having worked at companies such as Apple, Sun Microsystems and eBay. She headed corporate venturing and strategic alliances at HP and prior to taking the role at CSAA, she was global head of the innovation network at Citigroup. Coming into CSAA she was determined to build an innovation office that would oversee multiple activities, all closely coordinated with each other.

"My experiences at HP and Citi certainly informed how I set up the division at CSAA to be able to increase the odds of having successful outcomes," she says.

One of the key skills is pushing for change at a pace that a company can digest. "The world is changing around us all the time. But the reality is that people, customers and employees do not want it to change too much, too fast," says Brackeen. She is a believer in "ambidextrous innovation" where new ideas are nurtured alongside making sure that the established business is continuously innovating and running well.

"How do you optimise and grow your core while you are inventing something new or determining where you need to place your next set of bets? That is the game in my opinion," she says. ■



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We are not investing solely for financial returns; our primary measure is strategic value. We invest in really good companies relevant to our long-term strategy, and we try to partner with them to create some form of commercial value

Amy Burr

President **JetBlue Ventures**

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JetBlue Ventures, the corporate venture capital subsidiary of US-based airline operator JetBlue, is led by president Amy Burr. The firm was founded in 2016 and focuses on investments that advance the travel, transportation and hospitality industries. It has 23 active portfolio companies and scored seven exits.

Burr took over the reins of the unit during the covid-19 pandemic and lead it through the difficult challenges that came as most of the travel sector was shut down.

But JetBlue has made the most of the post-pandemic recovery and Burr is especially proud of the team's performance in the past year. "It has been one of our best years," she says. "We made nine new investments and six follow-on deals." One exit occurred in the past 12 months, when ticket management and reservation software company Betterez was acquired by Busbud.

Burr acknowledges the team's strong performance in 2022 was in part due to the macroeconomic environment. The travel sector has proved more resilient than many other parts of the economy. "Our industry has been fortunate to have so much pent-up demand for travel. As a result, we are doing well and are blessed to have strong tailwinds".

Today, Burr is most excited about opportunities in sustainable travel and artificial intelligence data tools to achieve operational efficiencies. Such data-driven efficiency needs are endemic to the travel industry and have room for growth, according to Burr. Recent investments include funding for Shift5, a cybersecurity company specialised in preventing hacks on transport data networks, and backing short-term rental company Frontdesk. JetBlue Ventures also participated in the \$25m series A funding round for Kresus, a web3 app that lets users manage their digital assets.

The CVC unit invests from the balance sheet of JetBlue, but has considerable autonomy. The unit has a mandate to make investments with strategic value.

"The CVC unit has two very real functions – investing for the corporate parent and bringing innovation to the industry," says Burr. Financial performance, however, is still important, "We are measuring total value to paid in and internal rate of return. We are doubling down on our financial focus now."

Before assuming her current role in July 2021, Burr served for three years as managing director of operations and partnerships. In this role, she worked closely with the portfolio companies in travel and hospitality, helping to integrate startups into the airline's overall corporate innovation initiatives.

Burr has been involved in the airline and travel industry for more than 23 years. She joined Continental Airlines in 2000, leaving in 2004 to join as a founder of Virgin America. Burr stayed with Virgin America until it was acquired by Alaska Airlines, "I have seen the entire cycle of a startup – the building of the company and the acquisition by Alaska Airlines. I truly can empathise with the founders of our portfolio companies."

Burr leads a team of 12 people – four of whom she hired in the past year. "We have a strong culture," she says. "We are very inclusive in our decision making, ensuring everyone enjoys their time here, while also growing professionally."

Burr credits her mentors for helping her become the strong female CVC leader she is today. "I have had strong female mentors along the way," says Burr. "One of them was Bonny Simi, who co-founded and led this organisation before me. She saw immediately the potential in me to lead, so she taught me all I needed to know about venture capital."

As a leader, Burr is admired by her team members and has earned the respect of those who work for and with her. "Amy does a phenomenal job leading the JBV team, and we are looking forward to seeing her continue to bring her innovation experience to life as part of JetBlue's leadership team," says Brandon Nelson, JetBlue's general counsel and corporate secretary. ■



It has been one of our best years. We made nine new investments and six follow-on deals. Our industry has been fortunate to have so much pent-up demand for travel. As a result, we are doing well and are blessed to have strong tailwinds

Tony Cannestra

Director of corporate ventures **Denso International America**

Tony Cannestra has been director of corporate ventures at vehicle parts maker Denso International America for the past 10 years. He leads the company's strategic investing efforts and has set up an investing strategy for the Japan-headquartered corporate by establishing an extensive network of universities, entrepreneurs, incubators, accelerators, angel investor groups and venture capital funds.

Denso's corporate venturing unit invests in early-stage startups that are compatible with the parent company's strategic growth plan through equity investments and non-equity funding, as well as mergers and acquisitions. Target companies are typically involved in mobility areas such as connectivity, autonomous vehicles and cybersecurity. Recently, the unit is exploring new investment areas such as wellness, advanced materials

and circular economy. The unit has a portfolio of 18 active startups.

Recent investments include a role as lead investor on the \$21m series B round for quadric.io, a developer of machine learning systems, and involvement in the latest funding round for additive manufacturing startup Seurat.

Cannestra serves as board director for a number of Denso portfolio companies, including Blaize, which develops artificial intelligence-based computing solutions, cybersecurity startup Dellfer and Canatu, a carbon nanotube startup based in Finland.

Before his role at Denso, Cannestra spent five years as managing partner of venture capital firm Strategic Venture Partners. Before that, he was a principal and later an executive vice president of fund manager Ignite and a board member of energy storage company Cymbet Corporation. ■



Denso invests in early-stage startups that are compatible with the parent company's strategic growth plan

Nazim Cetin

CEO **Allianz X**

Nazim Cetin has been at the helm of Allianz X since 2017. The digital investment arm of insurance provider and asset manager Allianz focuses on insurtech, fintech and other technologies adjacent to Allianz's core business. Cetin was instrumental in Allianz X's pivot from an accelerator and venture builder to a global investor in mature digital companies, which more recently acquired a number of them, including ControlExpert, GT Motive and Innovation Group.

Cetin sits on the boards of five of the unit's portfolio companies, including financial advisory platform Wealthsimple, small business insurance provider Pie Insurance – for which Allianz X co-led a \$315m series D round late last year – digital insurance broker, and digital banking and lending company WeLab.

Other notable startups in the investor's

stable include cyber insurtech Coalition – whose \$250m series F funding round it led last year – rent-to-buy home purchase service Wayhome, and derivatives analytics provider OpenGamma.

Cetin moved to Allianz X after serving as vice president of corporate development and new businesses at media conglomerate Bertelsmann, a post that followed previous financial roles such as vice president of commercial finance for Maple Bank and investment banking at LBBW.

Cetin also founded Agora 42, the first periodical in Germany focused on economics and philosophy.

He received his first degree in quantitative economics at Eberhard Karls University, followed by an MSc in economics and management from Universitat Pompeu Fabra and his PhD in economics from Witten-Herdecke University. ■



Cetin was instrumental in Allianz X's pivot from an accelerator and venture builder to an investor in mature digital companies

Young-Joon Choi

President and CEO **Samsung Ventures**



Samsung Venture Investment has more than \$1.8bn under management and invests \$250m annually

Young-Joon Choi is president and CEO of Samsung Venture Investment, a corporate venturing subsidiary of South Korean electronics manufacturing conglomerate Samsung.

Choi started as a member of the corporation's accounting group in 1984, with a large part of his career spent with Samsung's corporate strategy office. From 2000, he spent nearly a decade at the Samsung Strategic Planning Office, before taking several other roles at Samsung Electronics, Samsung Card and Samsung Futures. He was named CEO and president of Samsung Venture Investment in late 2020.

Formed in 1999, Samsung Venture Investment has more than \$1.8bn under management and invests \$250m annually, covering South Korea, the US, India, Japan, China, Israel and Europe.

Samsung Venture Investment makes

stage-agnostic investments, early to pre-IPO stage and concentrates on semiconductors, telecommunication, software, internet, bioengineering, carbon capture, medical technologies, fintech and insurtech.

The unit has more than 80 active portfolio companies, having invested in 550 startups. Samsung Venture Investment has also scored exits including enterprise data storage company Pure Storage and streaming television service Pluto TV.

Samsung is a \$262.8bn conglomerate specialising in various forms of technologies. It also operates two other corporate venturing units: Samsung Next and Samsung Catalyst Fund, in addition to several other daughter businesses such as Samsung Electronics, Samsung Heavy Industries and Samsung Life Insurance. ■

Rob Coppedge

CEO **Echo Health Ventures**



Coppedge leads a team that identifies, invests in and helps grow innovative companies in healthcare and insurance

Rob Coppedge is the CEO of Echo Health Ventures, which was formed from the merger of Cambia Health Solutions and Mosaic Solutions, a subsidiary of Blue Cross and Blue Shield of North Carolina.

Coppedge leads a team that identifies, invests in and helps grow innovative companies in healthcare and insurance. With more than 20 years of experience in healthcare venture capital, Coppedge joined Cambia Health in 2010 as vice president of business and corporate development. He helped to create Echo Health Ventures in 2016.

In 2021, Echo launched its investment platform, Echo Innovation Alliance, which brings together several Blue Cross Blue Shield companies to take healthcare innovation to a national scale. One of Coppedge's key goals is driving large-scale change across the US healthcare sector.

Prior to joining Cambia, Coppedge was the founding partner of Faultline Ventures, a US-based venture capital firm. Prior to that, he was a partner at healthcare IT-focused VC firm Capitol Health Partners. Coppedge has a bachelor's degree in history from Georgetown University in Washington DC.

Echo has 30 active portfolio companies, having made more than 75 investments. Recent deals include backing the \$75m funding round of Coritica, a US-based startup providing advanced neurological therapies for children with autism. Echo also led the \$35m series B funding round for Medix Infusion, a startup providing mobile infusion services – intravenous administration of medications – to patients in rural and other under-served communities. ■

Barbara Dalton

Senior managing partner **Pfizer Ventures**

Barbara Dalton has been running Pfizer Ventures, the US-listed drugs company Pfizer's corporate venturing arm, since she joined in 2007 as vice president.

Dalton's team invests around \$50m a year in tranches of up to \$15m per round and concentrates primarily on therapeutics businesses. She has managed more than 130 fund investments, and while the unit is mainly focused on US-based companies, up to 20% of the portfolio can be represented by international investees. Dalton has direct investing responsibility for biotechnology therapeutic and platform companies, as well as healthcare IT and service businesses.

In 2022, Pfizer Ventures made 10 new investments, while 10 of the unit's portfolio companies closed follow-on financings, raising a cumulative total in excess of \$1bn. Recent

investments include playing a lead role on series B rounds for Grey Wolf Therapeutics and Storm Therapeutics. In 2023, Pfizer Ventures sees 'significant potential' in advances in genetic medicine and tissue-specific delivery to create breakthroughs for patients.

Dalton has three decades of experience in the pharmaceutical industry starting when she took the role of president of UK-based pharmaceutical company GSK's corporate venturing unit, SR One, in 1993. After formally leaving SR One in 2003, Dalton joined EuclidSR Partners, a \$260m venture firm set up in 2000 and backed by GSK, before moving to Pfizer four years later. She received the Global Corporate Venturing Lifetime Achievement award in 2019.

Dalton has a PhD in microbiology and immunology from Medical College of Pennsylvania and a BA from Penn State. ■



Dalton has direct investing responsibility for biotechnology therapeutic and platform companies

Scott Darling

President **Dell Technologies Capital**

Scott Darling has led Dell Technologies Capital, the corporate development and venture capital arm of Dell Technologies, since September 2016. The venture team pursues new and emerging enterprise technologies investments at a pace of approximately \$200m per year.

Recent investments by the unit include taking part in the \$44m series A funding round for cyber security startup Halcyon, and putting a large injection of cash into the \$27m seed funding round for Israeli startup Quantum Source, which is aiming to develop a commercially viable photonic quantum computer with millions of qubits.

Other investments include jointly leading the \$7m seed funding round for Distyl AI, a California-based company that turns large language models into products that large companies can use.

Darling's investment portfolio with Dell Technologies Capital includes current portfolio companies Exotec and a stealth Risc-V concern. Exited portfolio companies include DocuSign and Zscaler, where he serves on the board of directors.

Before Dell, Darling was president of EMC corporate development and ventures from March 2012, having joined the company after a five-year stint at venture capital firm Frazier Technology Ventures. EMC was merged into Dell in a \$67bn deal in 2016, after which Darling took up his current role.

Darling's corporate venturing and technology roots stretch back further, having originally joined chip maker Intel, which primarily powered Dell's personal computers, in 1990. Darling switched from marketing to Intel Capital in 2000 before leaving for Frazier in 2007. ■



The venture team pursues new and emerging enterprise technologies investments at a rate of around \$200m per year

Jurgen Eckhardt

➤FEATUREDENTRY

Executive VP and head **Leaps by Bayer**



Jurgen Eckhardt is the executive vice president and head of Leaps by Bayer, the impact investment unit of Germany-headquartered life science company Bayer.

Eckhardt has a background in both medicine and venture capital. He graduated with an MD from the University of Basel and earned an MBA from Insead Business School. He joined Bayer in 2016 to help develop Leaps. Previously, he was the head of private equity and venture capital at Bellevue Asset Management and prior to that an associate principal at McKinsey. He started his career as a resident physician in radiology at the University Hospital of Basel.

Both careers have taught him the value of sifting through large amounts of information to find that one crucial investment opportunity. “We see many potential opportunities and we need to find and execute on the best ones, as well as convince the companies we choose to invest in that we are the right partner,” he says.

Leaps by Bayer was founded in 2015 and has gradually increased its investing power over the past eight years. It now has more than \$1.7bn invested in a portfolio of more than 55 companies. In 2022, Leaps announced a commitment to invest another €1.3bn through 2024.

The Leaps investment focus covers both healthcare and agriculture.

“Life science remains the key focus for Leaps, as articulated in our ‘10 Leaps’ – ten huge challenges that we are aiming to solve by investing in breakthrough technologies. Our 10 Leaps include goals such as to potentially cure or prevent cancer, reverse chronic inflammation and autoimmune disease and reduce the environmental impact of agriculture. Those are all areas that could create a huge impact and where tomorrow’s biotech solutions may shift paradigms,” says Eckhardt.

Leaps publicly disclosed participation in 15 financing rounds in 2022 and has had several recent exits for companies in its portfolio. The venturing arm has had more than 10 exits in total over the years,

including several acquisitions of companies by Bayer.

Last August, Bayer acquired a majority share of the Leaps portfolio company CoverCress, which developed a genetically edited cover crop that can be planted in fields while they are being rested from other harvests, increasing soil health and creating new opportunities to then be turned into biofuel or animal feed.

One of the Leaps portfolio companies, Recursion Pharmaceuticals, which is developing a machine learning-based drug discovery platform, listed on Nasdaq in 2021 with an initial valuation of \$2.7bn.

Recent investments include taking part in the series A round of T-cell-based therapy developer Affini-T Therapeutics. The company’s therapies are expected to advance to Phase I trials this year. Leaps also backed the \$22m fundraise of Fork and Good, a US company developing cultivated pork using cultured muscle cells. Finding new sources of protein to sustainably feed a population of 10 billion by 2050 is one of the global challenges that Leaps by Bayer focuses on.

Eckhardt heads a team of 20, including ten VC experts, as well as branding and back-office functions. The team takes a hand-on role in steering the companies in the portfolio, an approach Leaps calls “active incubation”, where experienced CVC team members provide resources and strategic planning for the startup.

Despite the difficult macroeconomic conditions in 2022 and this year, Leaps by Bayer has stayed on course and continued investing in the most promising founder teams.

“It is not so different from what we have done in the past,” says Eckhardt. “For founders, it is of the utmost importance to have investors on their side who support them in the long run and provide them the opportunity to build a strong, sustainable team, technology and, ultimately, business model. This is what we will continue to do in 2023 and beyond.” ■

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We see many potential opportunities and we need to find and execute on the best ones, as well as convince the companies we choose to invest in that we are the right partner

Shereen El Zarkani

►FEATUREDENTRY

Managing partner **Maersk Growth**

At the time Powerlist 2023 was compiled, Shereen El Zarkani was managing partner of Maersk Growth, the corporate venture arm of AP Moller Maersk, one of the largest shipping container companies in the world. She had stepped down from the unit by the time of going to press.

Nevertheless, we have kept El Zarkani and Maersk Growth in this list, reflecting a strong 2022 for the unit and also in acknowledgement of the particular approach that El Zarkani brought to the investment team.

While many units are run by someone with an investment-based background, she brought experience in marketing, business development and strategy to the role, as well as sales and a different perspective.

"I have experience with people and with customer problems, and I think the idea was to also bring commercial knowledge and understanding of the customer landscape into what we do here," says El Zarkani.

The unit has made more than 30 investments since it was launched in 2017 and currently manages roughly \$500m, having closed its second venture fund last year and added a separate allocation for green fuel investments. It also operates a venture client service for its parent company, scouting for startups with products or services that can help solve a problem one of its business units might be having.

The logistics industry is going through a period of rapid adjustment in the wake of the coronavirus pandemic, which showed the fragility of global supply chains. Maersk Growth is tasked with helping its parent company move from being a container specialist into something much more modern and flexible.

"We are in the midst of a very intense transformation, from being just a shipping line moving stuff in containers to an end-to-end integrated logistics company powered by technology," says El Zarkani. "We are very deliberate in that we want to do it with technology and not by throwing armies of people at it, as is typically done in our industry.

"The pandemic showed what we already knew, but maybe the rest of the world was not aware of: how fragmented and fragile supply chains are. Everybody suffered in the past couple of years in some shape or form and we believe the underlying cause is a lack of technology."

In practice, that means Maersk Growth funds everything from Pactum, which is a developer of software that uses AI to negotiate contracts, to autonomous yard truck developer Isee and Afresh, the creator of an inventory software platform that helps grocery retailers reduce waste. All three were part of a dozen investments disclosed last year.

"We are very excited," says El Zarkani. "We think there are a number of cool emerging trends that are coming and, the current economic situation notwithstanding, it is really important to realise the fundamental issues with the supply chain did not go away. People just stopped buying and spending as much."

El Zarkani took care to build a team with a lot of commercial experience that can be passed on to portfolio companies. Maersk Growth holds enterprise selling workshops, where they help startups with their go-to-market strategy. El Zarkani's background in running a large sales operation meant she knew startups' potential customers by name, which stakeholders they needed to work with and how to navigate with each one of them.

El Zarkani says that working in corporate venturing had meant making some adjustments in leadership style.

"From a leadership perspective, I was used to leading fairly large teams," she says. "We had 3,000 salespeople and now it is a team of about 25. We are a lot more hands-on and we work at multiple levels, so I needed to adjust and reinvent the way I lead."

"It is really about bringing that commercial knowledge and understanding and helping the startups navigate Maersk, so we can accelerate our own transformation, as well as unlocking growth for the companies." ■



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It is really about bringing that commercial knowledge and understanding and helping the startups navigate Maersk, so we can accelerate our own transformation, as well as unlocking growth for the companies

Roe Furman

➤FEATUREDENTRY

Managing director **Doral Energy-Tech Ventures**



Roe Furman is managing director of Doral Energy-Tech Ventures (Doral-Tech), the climate-tech corporate venture capital arm set up by Israel-based renewable energy company Doral Renewable Energy Resources Group.

"We have had a busy year," says Furman, summarising the past 12 months in which the team made six new global investments, a number of applied research programmes sponsored by Doral-Tech matured, several early-stage startups successfully finished Doral-Tech's acceleration programme and a number of strategic collaborations between startup companies and Doral-Tech began.

In the past 12 months, Doral-Tech made its first investment in Germany with Reverion, a spin-off from the Technical University of Munich, developing a reversible fuel-cell system that electro-chemically converts biogas or hydrogen into electricity with an efficiency of 80% and can switch to electrolysis mode to produce green hydrogen or methane. Doral-Tech also co-invested with Saudi Aramco Ventures in Noon Energy, a US startup company developing long-duration, low-cost carbon-based batteries.

Its portfolio companies AM Batteries secured \$25m series A funding and Ascend Elements launched the largest battery recycling plant in the US, after closing a significant series C round and gaining an additional \$480m Department of Environment grant. Doral-Tech also participated in Quino Energy and CaPow seed rounds, as well as co-leading the seed round of Helios, along with At One Ventures. The unit also co-led an investment along with TDK Ventures and Breakthrough Energy Ventures in US-based fusion energy company Type One Energy.

Doral-Tech was established in late 2020 following the unit's first investment, Phinergy, a pioneer in metal-air technologies. The company secured a 32% return for Doral-Tech when it was listed on the Tel Aviv stock exchange. This success story was a perfect head start for Doral

Energy-Tech Ventures and was followed by a design partnership agreement for a long-duration energy storage project.

The investment arm started with an initial annual budget of NIS50m (\$15.3m), which was doubled in the second year to deploy in early-stage energy and climate-tech startups. It was set up to help Doral-Tech gain a competitive edge over other energy companies, alongside enjoying exceptional financial returns.

Before Furman took on the role, he made sure that he got full support from the management team. "I had to make sure that we were patient and willing to take risks, especially at early stages," says Furman. "I also wanted to make sure we could move fast. We have been working around the clock to become relevant."

Net-zero projects are a big investment focus for Doral-Tech. "We are really excited about opportunities in green molecules – anything from green ammonia and hydrogen, through green fertilizers to sustainable aviation fuels. Another exciting area is the carbon-to-value space, which tackles the issue of what to do with CO₂ when we capture it. We are also looking into energy management and energy trading technologies," he says.

Doral-Tech has a collaborative code of conduct, says Furman. "We are all very honest and open to new ideas and we act without ego. To me, it is all about collaborative team effort," he says.

Most recently, Furman hired a new team member with a background in regulation and public utilities to help support its portfolio with value creation.

Prior to Doral-Tech, Furman was responsible for strategy and business development at Maisha-Labs, the digital healthcare subsidiary of Maisha Group. There he participated directly in intrapreneurship himself. He led a strategic project for a Canadian healthcare network that included the development of an AI-driven platform to predict and optimise patient flow. ■



I had to make sure that we were patient and willing to take risks, especially at early stages. I also wanted to make sure we could move fast. We have been working around the clock to become relevant

Jenna Foger

SVP, science and technology **Alexandria Venture Investments**

Jenna Foger has headed up the corporate venturing activities of Alexandria – a New York-based real-estate business with a focus on the life sciences sector – since 2014. During that time, she has seen the total number of deals made by Alexandria Venture Investments rise to more than 200, as well as successful exits for portfolio companies including covid-19 vaccine-maker Moderna, agtech firm Benson and cancer therapy developer Acrivon Therapeutics.

Recent investments by Alexandria Venture Investments include participation in a \$28m series A round for precision medicine company Function Oncology and a role in the \$87m series C raise for Ring Therapeutics, a gene therapy specialist. The unit has also backed Chroma Medicine, which focuses on epigenetic editing technology, in a \$135m series B round.

Alexandria Venture Investments set up

its Seed Capital Platform in 2018 with the intention of accelerating seed funding for life sciences technology developers by bringing together participants from across the healthcare venture capital sector. It followed the creation a year earlier of life science startup accelerator Alexandria LaunchLabs, which was initially based in New York City but which now has a number of locations in the US.

Before joining Alexandria, Foger was an associate at Windham Venture Partners, where she assisted in expanding the healthcare venture fund with a particular focus on medical technology, diagnostics, and digital health investments.

Foger also has laboratory experience as a research associate at the Rockefeller University, where she completed her master's degree in biotechnology from Columbia University. ■



Foger has seen the total number of deals made by Alexandria Venture Investments rise to more than 200

Gonzalo Galindo Gout

President **Cemex Ventures**

Gonzalo Galindo Gout has been head of Cemex Ventures, the corporate venture capital and open innovation arm of Mexico-based construction business Cemex, since it was launched in 2017. The unit focuses on four key investment areas: green construction, construction supply chain, enhance productivity and the future of construction.

Cemex Ventures invests in construction technology-focused disruptive startups that can provide answers to real daily-basis problems happening in the construction value chain. Apart from making investments, the unit also helps early-stage companies that need support in their market growth process through pilots, research and development testing activities, or by giving them access to its network of partners including other investors, VCs, accelerators, investment funds, clients,

suppliers and academia. Cemex Ventures has also launched a number of in-house incubated solutions to attend to the specific needs of the core business.

In 2017, Cemex Ventures launched the Construction Startup Competition, a mechanism for startups to bring their solutions to a global stage and benefit from the relationships formed with the Cemex Ventures ecosystem and other outstanding startups. Startups from 80 countries have participated to date.

Among the unit's recent investments are StructShare, an order-management app; clean energy startup WtEnergy; Cobod, a global leader in construction-grade 3D printers; and ObraLink, a construction technology developer. It has a portfolio of more than 20 businesses.

Galindo Gout worked at McKinsey as a management consultant before joining Cemex. ■



Apart from making investments, the unit also helps early-stage companies that need support in their market growth process

Jim Gable

President **Chevron Technology Ventures**

FEATURED ENTRY



Jim Gable is president of Chevron Technology Ventures (CTV), which serves as the US oil and gas major's primary on-ramp for early-stage external innovation. Gable has spent nearly his entire career at Chevron, working in various parts of the business, including running a refinery and a chemical plant.

Gable headed the VC unit of CTV between 2003 and 2007, not long after the organisation was established in 1999 and rejoined as president in March 2022.

Gable leads a team of 60 employees with diverse experience and deep technical backgrounds, with about 14 team members dedicated to CTV's venture capital work. More than double that number work in transferring external technology into the parent company, a job Gable describes as a "contact sport".

"You have to walk the halls, have good business and personal networks. We have more people focused on that and helping technologies move through Chevron than we have people doing investments themselves."

CTV primarily hires internally, hoping to capitalise on institutional knowledge and established relationships with business units. Gable says internal hires who know the ins and outs of the parent business tend to do well at CTV.

"On the technology transfer side, it helps to have someone with a background of working in business units that can help us with the transfer of technologies into the business. The close connections with the business and its pain points are particularly important for several aspects of what we do."

With those connections, doors open more readily for CTV's project managers who work closely with CTV technology scouts to identify potential solutions for business problems across the enterprise and develop trial opportunities to de-risk the technologies.

A large part of the unit's focus is on technologies that reduce the carbon intensity of Chevron's operations, as well

as those that can enable lower carbon value chains. Of special interest are technologies that can support greater use of reliable renewable energy to provide the tens of gigawatts of power required for energy production.

CTV also focuses on carbon capture and renewable fuels that can use existing distribution infrastructure. It has made investing in the hydrogen value chain a priority and sees blue hydrogen as a bridge to emissions-free green hydrogen.

CTV has made 11 new investments in the past 12 months and achieved two exits: ChargePoint, an electric vehicle charging network, and ThoughtTrace, a document and contract analytics software company.

Gable sees CTV's role as helping startups to scale and commercialise technologies. The unit actively avoids taking board seats at startups to focus on commercialisation. This strategy enhances its reputation and credibility, as well as helping it access the best deals, says Gable.

"We generally only take board observer seats. We are not one of those corporates that tries to put in preferential rights or exclusive sales territories. If you start restricting with preferential rights, you will develop a reputation for not helping the entrepreneurs," he says.

A year and a half ago, Chevron launched Chevron New Energies that is specifically designed to commercialise and scale late-stage low-carbon technologies. It has taken in businesses such as carbon capture companies Carbon Clean and Svante, which started off as portfolio companies of CTV.

The unit is an active sponsor of university programmes and accelerators that build up the Houston energy ecosystem. It backs Greentown Labs, a climate tech startup incubator, and Activate Houston, a fellowship for science entrepreneurs.

It also partners with the US government-backed National Renewable Energy Laboratory on Chevron Studio, a project that connects university IP to entrepreneurs seeking their next gig. ■



You have to walk the halls, have good business and personal networks. We have more people focused on that and helping technologies move through Chevron than we have people doing investments themselves

Stefan Gabriel

FEATURED ENTRY

CEO and managing director **Hitachi Ventures**

"CVC is the new R&D," says Stefan Gabriel, managing director and chief executive of Hitachi Ventures. "Strategic corporate venturing adds significantly to corporate innovation and growth. If you invest in minority stakes in startups and foster their collaboration with business units and customers, you will quickly gain a lot of knowledge and insights from new markets, access new technologies and discover business solutions. In parallel, you should be a good investor and partner for startups, helping to grow and execute their business plan."

Gabriel, a 20-year veteran of corporate venturing, founded Hitachi Ventures in 2019 and is ambitious about the business value the unit can create for its parent company, Japanese conglomerate Hitachi. The unit aims to contribute to or initiate new business revenues worth millions of dollars for Hitachi over the next few years, Gabriel says.

Gabriel has a specific playbook for strategic CVC, including four key pillars that specifically add value to the corporate mothership: collaboration, strategy, entrepreneurship and culture.

Along with chief finance officer Wolfgang Seibold, he set up Hitachi Ventures to operate independently, while at the same time maintaining a close relationship with Hitachi's senior leadership to exchange strategies and insights to grow new business.

Hitachi is the sole limited partner in the Hitachi Ventures fund, but the CVC unit is a separate legal entity, with an independent investment committee. The team will take active roles on startup boards, either as a director or observer.

The ventures team is mostly made up of engineers and scientists with experience in strategy, business development and venture or private equity investing, rather than people with a financial background only, but all come from outside Hitachi and are incentivised in line with the fund's success.

"I report directly to the board, and we all communicate actively and align strategies with all executive stakeholders," Gabriel

says. "We exchange and discuss strategic plans, showcase opportunities and receive good advice from our Hitachi Ventures board. We help Hitachi do deep dives in specific areas and we have discussions around future trends and opportunities, what is happening in this space, how to build or how to grow a business."

Gabriel says that, if set up correctly, strategic venturing is a "tool" that corporates can use to experiment with emerging business areas, too, and inspire business units to expand their business.

The most valuable thing an investment can give to a corporate is insights and network, says Gabriel, who was formerly president of 3M's global CVC unit. "It is not only about the multiples of valuation. Learning from startups to guide new strategies, new business opportunities and understanding new markets, that is what corporate executives really want."

Hitachi Ventures has so far built a portfolio of 21 investments. The 15-person investment team will evaluate 1,000 startups a year, making around eight investments plus numerous follow-on investments a year. The company will invest an average of \$5m per deal as a first ticket, focusing on series A or B rounds, but keeps reserves for later stages. The aim is always to find startups that can enter a joint project and collaborate with Hitachi as soon as possible.

Hitachi Ventures works with a team of 14 open innovation and business development experts in the corporate venturing office at Hitachi, whose job it is to help initiate and manage collaboration projects between startups and business units. The two teams have jointly helped set up 80 joint projects between Hitachi and portfolio companies.

Hitachi Ventures recently raised a third, \$300m fund, doubling its firepower to \$600m. In a few more years the cumulative fund size should reach \$1bn.

All funds invest in digital, green, energy and mobility and connected industries, with the latest fund adding AI, web3 and B2B SaaS as additional focus areas. ■



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It is not only about the multiples of valuation. Learning from startups to guide new strategies, new business opportunities and understanding new markets, that is what corporate executives really want

Tarik Galijasevic

►FEATUREDENTRY

Managing director and head **Allstate Strategic Ventures**



Tarik Galijasevic is managing director of Allstate Strategic Ventures (ASV), the corporate venturing arm of US insurer Allstate. Formed in 2015, ASV invests in early-stage startups and entrepreneurs whose technologies will help shape the future of the insurance industry and adjacent sectors.

When it comes to ASV's investment strategy, artificial intelligence, machine learning and the supporting tech and data infrastructure are investments ASV prioritises since they are crucial to maximising Allstate's potential to serve customers.

"The customer is at the core of our investment strategy," says Galijasevic. "Everything we do is aimed at engaging with them at the point of decision, providing personalised products and services that meet their needs, and serving them as efficiently as possible."

ASV invests in series A to C funding rounds, with tickets sizes typically between \$1m and \$10m. Since it was founded, the corporate venturing team has expanded from focusing on Horizon 1 investments that bring near-term value to more longer-term Horizon 2 and 3 investments.

Although ASV does not disclose many of its investments, over the past year the team backed five new companies, such as code automation software provider Moderne, and conducted two-follow on deals. Moderne, a US-based startup that provides tools that automatically fix security vulnerabilities in computer code, raised a \$15m series A round in February 2023 and ASV took part in the deal alongside Intel Capital.

Galijasevic puts great emphasis on developing and training his team.

"I take immense pride in my team's accomplishments," says Galijasevic. "Through our rigorous training and development programme, we have nurtured several rising stars and emerging leaders who have grown as venture capital investors and individuals."

Francis Lowry, principal at ASV, was one

of Global Corporate Venturing's Emerging Leaders for 2023.

"Our efforts have helped them achieve their potential and allowed them to bring innovation and drive positive change in our organisation. It is a true testament to our commitment to building a better future for Allstate."

Over the past year, ASV promoted three members and hired analyst Olivia Bruno.

ASV embraces a flexible work environment and lets employees choose where they work. With ASV team members spread across the US and the UK, they have developed new ways to collaborate and put an emphasis on team development.

"As our team has grown, we have made a concerted effort to provide them with the best learning and development opportunities possible," says Galijasevic. "Our lunch and learns, constant mentoring and focus on market trends have set us apart as one of the top programmes in the industry."

Galijasevic is involved in various organisations and initiatives aimed at promoting innovation and collaboration in the venture capital ecosystem. ASV is a member of the Intellectual Capital Exchange, which brings together CVCs to share best practices and discuss topics relevant to the innovation ecosystem. The team also participates in the Global Midwest Alliance, focusing on bringing funding to the Chicago area.

"I'm optimistic about the future of the industry and the role that CVCs will play in driving growth and innovation," says Galijasevic. "I believe the key to success is being a disciplined investor, but also being flexible to adapt to the changing landscape of venture capital."

Galijasevic started his career at JPMorgan, where he worked in private equity, mergers and acquisitions and capital raising in the transportation and consumer goods sectors. He joined ASV in 2013 after he quickly realised his passion for the venture capital industry. ■



I believe the key to success is being a disciplined investor, but also being flexible to adapt to the changing landscape of venture capital

Abhijit Ganguly

Managing director **Goodyear Ventures**

Abhijit Ganguly is managing director of Goodyear Ventures, the corporate venturing unit set up by US tyre manufacturer Goodyear. He is responsible for leading the venture fund.

At the time of launch, Goodyear's CEO Richard Kramer said: "Goodyear is a technology-driven mobility company that seeks out and partners with other mobility thought leaders ranging from small startups to proven business models. Goodyear Ventures will take this effort to the next level to engage and shape how people move in the future."

In his past roles, Abhijit led Goodyear's Corporate Incubator, focusing on IoT-enabled solutions businesses. Before joining Goodyear, Ganguly was responsible for driving growth initiatives in West Africa and Canada for a manufacturing company.

Goodyear Ventures' most significant exit is

the IPO of portfolio company TuSimple, a San Diego-based developer of self-driving trucks, which was valued at \$8.5bn when it went public on the Nasdaq exchange in 2021.

Among its recent investments are a role in the \$30m series C round for Get Spiffy, a digitally powered mobile car care company, and participation in the \$25m series B raise by India-based electric vehicle last-mile delivery company Zypp Electric. Goodyear Ventures also joined the \$5m seed round for advanced driver assistance system training company Ottometric and the \$31m series C raise for Helm.ai, a developer of AI technology for autonomous driving systems.

He has an MBA from the Tuck School of Business at Dartmouth. He co-authored two articles on business model innovation and received the 2015 Maurice Holland Award for his contributions in the field of business model Innovation. ■



Goodyear Ventures will take this effort to the next level to engage and shape how people move in the future

Hakan Goker & Owen Lozman

Managing directors **M Ventures**

Hakan Goker and Owen Lozman co-lead M Ventures, the corporate venturing unit of Germany-based pharmaceutical firm Merck Group. Goker heads the unit's biotechnology investments, covering healthcare and life sciences, while Lozman is responsible for technology investments, including electronics, frontier tech and sustainability.

The Netherlands-based unit has been involved in the creation and progress of some 80 businesses since it was set up, originally as MS Ventures, in 2009. It has four dedicated areas of operation: healthcare, life sciences, electronics and sustainability. Merck's strategic initiatives also include Merck Accelerator and collaboration programmes to accelerate innovation.

"Over the past decade, M Ventures has established itself globally as a leading partner to the biotech and tech venture ecosystems,"

said Belén Garijo, chair of the executive board and CEO of Merck, in 2021.

Among its recent investments are Actithera, a radio-molecular therapeutics company in the US; Astraveus, a microfluidics-based cell and gene therapy company in France; Lightcast, a single-cell analysis company; Iktos, an AI-driven drug discovery company in France; Genopore, a technology company for proteomics based in Israel; PxE, a developer of 3D imaging technology; and a role in the \$14m seed round for liquid-analysis firm Unisers.

Goker joined M Ventures in 2013. He was previously a partner at Aescap Venture and Atlas Venture investing in biotechnology and medtech opportunities. Lozman joined M Ventures in February 2018. His previous role was as head of new platform R&D for Merck's electronics business in Germany. ■



Hakan Goker



Owen Lozman

Michelle Gonzalez

►FEATUREDENTRY

Vice president and global head **M12**



Michelle Gonzalez is corporate vice president and global head of M12, Microsoft's venture capital fund. In this role, she leads the fund's investor strategy, research, portfolio development, marketing and business management activities. In the six years since M12 was founded, it has invested in more than 100 companies, including 15 unicorns and five of its portfolio companies have exited through IPOs.

M12's unit is in a period of change. In January 2023, Gonzalez announced unit was being reorganised so that it was more strategically aligned with parent company Microsoft. Several team members have reportedly left since the changes, but M12 appears to be investing at a steady pace so far in 2023.

M12's investment strategy is to back early-stage companies that are leveraging emerging technologies to disrupt traditional industries. The fund focuses on companies in specific areas aligned to Microsoft's expertise, including AI, cloud infrastructure, cybersecurity, developer tools, vertical SaaS, web3 and gaming. While strategic alignment to Microsoft plays a part in M12's investment criteria, its investment bar and process rigour mirrors a financial investor, says Gonzalez.

The fund invests independently of Microsoft's business and product groups. Recent investments include participation in a \$4m follow-on round for Metrika, a blockchain and risk management platform; and a \$65m round for Typeface, a generative AI application for enterprise content creation.

M12 aims to be a strategic partner to its portfolio companies, providing them with access to Microsoft's resources, network and technology to help accelerate their growth. As part of this charter, before every investment, its investors identify the unique value they can add to these startups. To meet this commitment, more than half of the 30-person M12 team is focused on helping portfolio companies realise their growth objectives.

This effort is also a big part of M12's approach to retaining staff. The fund offers a strong sense of purpose and mission and provides the team with challenging work and opportunities for growth and development.

While M12 does not disclose its fund size or financial metrics, it is a long-term investor and supports its portfolio companies through their lifecycle. As the deployment of capital has slowed over the past year due to global macroeconomic conditions, M12 continues to invest in series A and B-stage companies in its core interest areas. In addition, the fund has prioritised its strategic initiatives, including increasing its AI focus, learning from and sharing insights with key stakeholders at Microsoft, building a diverse team and portfolio, and ensuring its companies have access to the connections, customers and benefits to succeed in a downturn.

As M12 has refined its strategy over the past year, the fund takes pride in its ability to maintain its autonomy in its investment decisions. Many CVCs are often not the ultimate decision makers when it comes to where and how to invest, but by design, M12 is empowered here. It has also benefited from its proximity to Microsoft leaders. The fund has dedicated time with the senior leaders at Microsoft. Several times a year it provides updates to and puts its portfolio companies in front of the CEO and other senior executives to pitch new ideas and share insights.

During Gonzalez's time at the fund, it has increased engagement with Microsoft stakeholders and its portfolio companies. It also partnered with internet hosting service GitHub to launch the M12 GitHub Fund in November 2022. The fund invests in open-source startups developing on GitHub's platform. The companies are at seed stage, which is where M12 says it can have the biggest impact on the startups' development.

Gonzalez has a juris doctor's degree in law from Yale Law School. ■

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M12 aims to be a strategic partner to its portfolio companies, providing them with access to Microsoft's resources, network and technology to help accelerate their growth

Angie Grimm

Managing partner and global head **IBM Ventures**

Angie Grimm has been managing partner and global head of IBM Ventures, US-based technology provider IBM's corporate investment arm, since 2019. IBM Ventures invests in early-stage startups that are providing innovative technologies to the enterprise. The unit invests in select enterprise software companies across five themes: data and AI, security, sustainability, automation and quantum computing.

While IBM Ventures was initially formed in 2001, making it one of the more seasoned open innovation players, its mission was recently reimagined to focus on investing with a "capital plus" model. The unit invests capital in high-growth innovators, plus taps into a wide IBM network to help bring value to partners.

IBM Ventures works closely with subject

matter experts in IBM businesses to support innovation initiatives and investments. The team serves as a strategic unit of IBM that provides 'headlights' into market disruptions. The team then engages with the best startups to help solve the business problems of both IBM and its enterprise clients.

Among the unit's recent investments include innovators in Quantum Computing such as Qunasys and Strangeworks, security vendors Cyolo and Lightspin, and data infrastructure providers such as SingleStore and Dremio.

Grimm has worked in a variety of roles at IBM since joining the company in 2002. She spent three years at the brokerage Donaldson, Lufkin, & Jenrette (DLJ) as an investment banker in Chicago and aided in establishing DLJ's European M&A and technology group in London. ■



The unit invests capital in high-growth innovators, plus taps into a wide IBM network to help bring value to partners

Edgar Hardless

CEO **SingTel Innov8**

Edgar Hardless has been CEO of SingTel Innov8, the corporate venturing unit of the Singapore-based telecoms company, for more than a decade. SingTel Innov8 was set up with a S\$200m (\$150m) fund in 2010, subsequently increased to \$250m and then \$350m in August 2022.

At the time of the latest capital injection, Hardless said: "SingTel Innov8 is empowered to move quickly to capture investment opportunities in the fast-paced venture market. Our mandate is flexible, allowing us to invest in both early and growth-stage companies. This additional funding and our proven approach will help drive further investment deal flow and greater collaboration with the startup ecosystem, unlocking more value for both the group and our portfolio companies."

SingTel Innov8's areas of interest include

5G, artificial intelligence, cybersecurity, the digital economy, sustainability and emerging technologies. It also seeks to form partnerships between portfolio companies and SingTel's business units across the Asia-Pacific region, which include Optus, Airtel and Telkomsel.

Among the unit's recent investments are roles as lead investor in two seed rounds, for Ferrum Health, developer of an AI-based patient safety platform for health systems, and sustainability software firm Handprint. SingTel Innov8 also backed PrivyID, a document management company, in its \$48m series C round.

Hardless stepped up to the CEO role from his position as vice president of strategic investments, held since 2008, and an earlier role held for two years as head of SingTel's first open innovation unit, focused on identifying emerging technologies. ■



SingTel Innov8 is empowered to move quickly to capture investment opportunities in the fast-paced venture market

Kent Helfrich

President **GM Ventures**



Helfrich is uniquely positioned to help bring innovation and technology solutions into our vehicles and operations

Kent Helfrich became executive VP and chief technology officer at US-based carmaker General Motors (GM), as well as president of its corporate venturing subsidiary, GM Ventures, in August 2021.

Helfrich replaced Matthew Tsien in these roles, following Tsien's retirement after 45 years with the company. At the time of his appointment, GM president Mark Reuss said: "With Kent's background and experience, he is uniquely positioned to help bring innovation and technology solutions into our vehicles, manufacturing facilities and operations."

Before taking on the role, Helfrich was GM's executive director of advanced technology and partnerships. He has also led GM's global electrification and battery systems team. GM Ventures partners and backs entrepreneurs working on mobility and automotive

technologies that can be adapted by GM's cars, manufacturing plants and operational teams.

Helfrich says it is important to understand that motor manufacturing is as much about art as science. "It is a technology industry, a heavy industry, a durable goods industry, but it is all about how good you look in that car," he said. "It is still very much an art and designed proposition. That leads us to have to invest in really awesome materials and display technologies, and methods of integrating the driver into the vehicle. That means GM Ventures has a lot of work to do."

Among the unit's recent deals are a participation in the \$34m series C round for RapidDeploy, which develops a workflow solution for public safety services, and a lead role in a series A raise of undisclosed size for battery management firm Lithion Recycling. ■

Derek Idemoto

Senior VP **Cisco Investments**



Idemoto has led more than 100 acquisitions and investments totalling \$20bn across Cisco's businesses

Derek Idemoto is senior VP of corporate development and Cisco Investments, leading Cisco's external innovation strategy and execution through acquisitions and investments.

Since joining Cisco in 2007, Idemoto has led more than 100 acquisitions and investments totalling \$20bn across Cisco's cybersecurity, collaboration, enterprise networking and cloud, as well as emerging technologies and incubations businesses. Recent acquisitions include Smartlook, Lightspin, Valtix and Opsani. Idemoto has also led some of Cisco's notable acquisitions, including Duo Security, Acacia Communications, Leaba Semiconductor and OpenDNS, among others.

Cisco Investments invests hundreds of millions of dollars a year on average, from series A to late-stage growth investments. Recent investments include participation in funding

rounds for Island, maker of a secure browser tailor-made for the enterprise, and Aisera, which delivers next-generation conversational AI-driven service experiences.

Idemoto spearheaded the launch of the Aspire Fund in 2020. The Aspire Fund is an initial \$50m fund to invest in diverse-led startups and venture funds that align to Cisco's innovation roadmap. Since then, Cisco Investments has invested in several venture funds and startups led by black, Latino, Asian and female founders and CEOs, including Plexo Capital, Acrew Capital, L'Attitude Ventures, Corellium and Voiceitt.

Before joining Cisco, Idemoto was the managing director of venture investment for Itochu Technology, the corporate venture capital arm of Itochu Corporation, leading IT investments for the company. ■

Kurt Kaltenegger

Head **ABB Technology Ventures**

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Power and automation group ABB's corporate venture unit has made big steps forward since Kurt Kaltenegger took charge in 2019, resulting in a 2022 where it invested \$100m across 13 deals – more than double the previous year and some four to five times the cash outlay.

"When we started ABB Technology Ventures around 2010, we had a typical CVC model where we invested in companies to explore new opportunities," says Kaltenegger, head of ABB Technology Ventures. "We invested in disruptive technologies outside our core technology and core business, just to learn. Our investment committee was anchored into the ABB R&D organisation."

"In 2020, ABB onboarded a new CEO who started decentralising our business organisation. At the same time, we decentralised the venture unit in a way that from 2020 onwards, we were doing venture-as-a-service for the business. It was a type of new business model in venturing."

This new decentralised model means there are four people in the core team, working with staff in the group's four business areas – electrification, motion, process automation and robotics and discrete automation – to find cooperation and partnership opportunities for a strategic investment. The move has helped to turbocharge ABB's VC investment.

"We have teams in these business areas who, with support from our team, are scouting and networking in the startup environment," says Kaltenegger. "And we have a very small and high-level team in the central function."

"That means business has skin in the game, and we realised one of the success factors is that when we sign a term sheet, we have already discussed a cooperation plan with the startup. We would not make an investment, and the division would not approve an investment, where they would not see a cooperation opportunity."

Kaltenegger was head of the group's China research centre when he helped form ABB Technology Ventures as its chief technology officer. When unit head Grant

Allen moved to Schneider VC, Kaltenegger took the reins. But he does not have a conventional background for a venture capital investor.

"My background is quantum physics and solid-state physics," says Kaltenegger. "I have been at ABB for 32 years and during that time I learned about ABB technologies across the group and was very strongly involved in innovation and technology management."

Kaltenegger initially focused on technology strategy but became more involved in deals as time went on. He moved on to leading teams, and, when the time came, heading the unit was a natural step. "I was growing into that role from a technology background and was learning on legal and the financial side on the job, but nothing was really completely new to me after two decades of technology management in ABB," he says.

"When you are a technology manager in ABB, you have to take care of financials as well and you have some legal exposure, too. You know about IP and how it is handled in different countries, you have to manage teams and you have to build something more or less from scratch."

ABB Technology Ventures' areas of interest include robotics, cybersecurity, distributed energy, artificial intelligence, machine learning, electric mobility and smart buildings, and Kaltenegger pinpoints electrification and industry automation as sectors particularly primed for growth now. But it is not just the technology he finds fascinating about CVC, it is being able to interact with a community that shares ideas and influences how that technology develops.

"If we do four, 10 or 20 investments a year, it is fine, as it is not a KPI," he says. "The most important thing is how it impacts our strategy roadmap and R&D roadmaps, what can we change at ABB on a long-term horizon and how we generate business impact. How many successful partnerships can we develop from that investment? That is more important than the number of investments." ■



When you are a technology manager in ABB, you have to take care of financials as well and you have some legal exposure, too. You have to manage teams and you have to build something more or less from scratch

Soichi Kariyazono

➤FEATUREDENTRY

Co-founder and managing partner **Globis Capital Partners**



Soichi Kariyazono is a co-founding partner of Globis Capital Partners (GCP), a Japanese venture capital firm closely linked to the ecosystem of education services provider Globis. He has been with the company for more than 25 years, first as fund manager of the Globis Incubation Fund, before becoming a founding partner of the Apax Globis Japan Fund.

Kariyazono has played a pivotal role in GCP's growth over the years. Under his leadership, the firm has become one of the largest fund managers in Japan, raising capital from numerous institutional investors. In April 2023, it disclosed a seventh fund sized at ¥72.7bn (\$543m), the largest raised by the firm.

"We are one of the oldest independent venture capital firms in Japan, having started as a business division of the Globis Group," Kariyazono says. "The group has various initiatives including an MBA programme, corporate training, research and publication."

In the late 1990s, the venture capital division became independent through a 50/50 joint venture with Apex Partners. Since then, its management decisions have been separate from the educational arms of the Globis Group, making it a fully independent venture capital firm.

In addition, GCP launched a San Francisco office to strengthen support for the global expansion of its portfolio companies. "Our seventh fund is our largest fund to date, equivalent to around \$550m at the current rate," says Kariyazono.

"Our previous fund was around ¥40bn, so we have almost doubled the size. Over the past two years, our team has grown from 15 to 25 people to prepare for a larger fund and to focus on creating global unicorn companies."

The investment unit focuses on deeptech, digitalisation and software-as-a-service companies, and Kariyazono believes healthcare and robotics will be especially important in Japan. In the past year, the firm has invested ¥4bn in seven new

companies, ¥2.4bn for five follow-on deals, totalling ¥6bn (\$40m).

Around half of the 25-people team are investment professionals and the remainder are deal evaluation and administrative staff.

The GCP team helps portfolio companies with hiring, consultation and other areas. Recently, the unit has focused on changing the mindset of startups from being growth-orientated to sustainability-orientated, emphasising profitability and customer satisfaction. This approach has led to some successful exits, including M&A deals, especially in the healthcare and robotics sectors.

"We have been very mindful of the timing for exits, especially given the fluctuations in the capital markets, particularly in the SaaS area," says Kariyazono. "So while we have not seen any IPOs, we have had a few successful M&A exits in the past year."

"Our portfolio companies are generally doing well, given that the Japanese economy is holding steady. As for our management strategy, we have shifted our focus from simply pursuing higher growth to prioritising profitability and ensuring our companies have a runway of two to three years. We are not in a rush to exit and instead are waiting for the capital markets to open up."

Kariyazono's experience in management consulting at Sanwa Research Institute Corporation and his academic background, including a bachelor's degree in law from Keio University and an MBA from the University of Pittsburgh Graduate School of Business, have been valuable assets in his role at GCP.

In addition to leading the investment unit, Kariyazono is involved in various initiatives that promote innovation and entrepreneurship in Japan. He serves as an honorary chairman of the Japan Venture Capital Association. He also teaches at Globis University, the business school affiliated with Globis. ■

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We have shifted our focus from simply pursuing higher growth to prioritising profitability and ensuring our companies have a runway of two to three years

George Kellerman

►FEATUREDENTRY

VP and head of investments and acquisitions **Woven Capital**

George Kellerman has been with Woven by Toyota since 2020 and played a vital role in 2021 in setting up Woven Capital's \$800m global investment fund to broaden the corporation's global reach and to accelerate innovation.

Kellerman believes several sectors are emerging as strong areas of growth for the automotive sector, including the electrification of cars, factory automation, "specifically around cost savings in this current climate," he says. The team is also looking at the deployment of new fast-moving technology, including artificial intelligence, which Kellerman says traditional companies are exploring how to integrate technology into operations.

A venture capital veteran, Kellerman was previously CEO and managing director of Yamaha Motor Ventures. Prior to that he was managing partner and 'fire chief' for 500 Startups, a US-based venture capital firm.

Woven Capital has a team of 13, having doubled its size in the past year. Kellerman believes in giving his staff maximum autonomy. "Empowering our staff and providing them with the autonomy to source and lead their own deals is important for us," says Kellerman. "We equally value every team member's input and ideas, making sure they have a say in the decision-making and voting process."

Also, Kellerman's team all participate in carried interest arrangements, which also helps with motivation and retention.

The fund has both financial and strategic goals. "We utilise both traditional financial metrics commonly seen in VC funds, as well as internal metrics that measure value add such as cost savings and accelerated timelines for internal builds," says Kellerman.

Kellerman also liaises closely with Woven by Toyota. "We have developed a more focused investment strategy that aligns tightly with our parent company," Kellerman says.

"We engage with business unit leaders to develop a clear plan that includes specific

deliverables and milestones for the coming year. Our dedicated portfolio team works closely with all parties to ensure the plan is executed effectively and adjustments are made as necessary to drive value for our companies," says Kellerman.

Kellerman says in the current, challenging investment market the team will be working even more closely with Toyota business units to help their startup companies succeed.

Woven Capital has four portfolio companies, including Nuro, the California-based autonomous delivery startup, which raised \$600m in a series D round in 2021 and Tokyo-based short-distance mobility products designer Whill.

Working with inventors, Woven by Toyota is building Woven City as a smart city with more efficient mobility options. This means Woven Capital has the remit to look beyond just core automotive startups. Kellerman says the team is likely to diversify its investments even further now, and will look to co-invest with other funds.

"It might be easy to limit our horizons to technologies aimed specifically at moving people from A to B, but mobility involves an entire ecosystem of participation from payments systems to manufacturers, which we consider when it comes to investment," says Kellerman.

"Woven Capital plays a critical role in accelerating Toyota's transition from a global automobile manufacturer to a global mobility company," he says. "We exist to help Toyota solve real-world problems for customers and foster happiness and well-being by creating safe and intelligent mobility experiences. And we are proud of our role in supporting Toyota's broader strategy."

Woven Capital is highly active in the CVC ecosystem, participating in various events, including chairing the GCV Global Mobility Council. It also contributes in thought leadership content through Forbes Council and participates in the Fortune Brain Tech community. ■



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Empowering our staff and providing them with the autonomy to source and lead their own deals is important for us. We equally value every team member's input and ideas, making sure they have a say in the decision-making and voting process



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Dong-Su Kim

CEO **LG Technology Ventures**

Dong-Su Kim helped set up corporate venture capital fund LG Technology Ventures for South Korea-based electronics, chemical and telecoms conglomerate LG Group in 2018.

The unit oversees investments for LG Group affiliates – LG Electronics, LG Chem, LG Display and LG Uplus – which raised investment funds totalling \$400m when it was formed and now stands at \$680m. The unit identifies and invests in strategically relevant startups, especially those with technologies in artificial intelligence (AI), robotics and auto components including batteries.

In the past three years, the unit has increased its focus on AI, especially in the technology's ability to improve manufacturing supply chains, such as in preventative maintenance and defect inspection. It has more than 40 portfolio companies.

Among its recent investments, LG Technology

Ventures participated in the \$16.5m series B round for sustainable manufacturing company TripleW, as well as the \$100m series C raise for Humane, an AI-driven technology platform. Humane is working with LG on potential R&D projects for its next phase of products.

Before joining LG, Kim was US-based vice president and general manager for South Korea-listed electronics conglomerate Samsung's corporate venturing arm, Samsung Ventures America.

Kim led deals for Samsung in more than 20 companies, including data storage technology developer Pure Storage and memory-based IT infrastructure equipment manufacturer Netlist, which were floated on the New York and Nasdaq stock exchanges respectively. He has a PhD in electrical engineering from Princeton University. ■



The unit oversees investments for LG Group affiliates, which raised investment funds totalling \$400m when it was formed

Chase Koch

Founder and CEO **Koch Disruptive Technologies**

Chase Koch is the founder and CEO of Koch Disruptive Technologies (KDT), a subsidiary of Koch Industries. KDT focuses on partnering with principled entrepreneurs who are building transformative companies.

KDT's investment philosophy is to identify partners with aligned vision and values, as well as complementary capabilities. It can then use its large network of companies and partners to help a young company grow exponentially. By aligning incentives, the company aims to have a greater impact, learn new business models and technologies.

Among its recent deals are a lead role in the \$32m series C round for Silo, a company that provides software solutions and financial services for the agricultural supply chain and led a \$20m series A raise for Volumez, a cloud infrastructure startup.

KDT also took part in the \$90m venture round for Artera, an innovative firm using AI to personalise cancer therapies.

Chase is also the founder of Stand Together Ventures, a network of business leaders focused on developing transformative and disruptive solutions to break barriers that stand in the way of unleashing human potential. Chase also founded Stand Together Music, which unites musicians with proven change makers to co-create solutions to some of the most pressing problems in society today.

Before launching KDT, Chase served in multiple leadership positions at Koch Agronomic Services and Koch Fertilizer Company, in addition to serving as a financial analyst with Koch Equity Development Group. ■



KDT's investment philosophy is to identify partners with aligned vision and values, as well as complementary capabilities

Anja König

Global head **Novartis Venture Fund**



Anja König is the global head of Novartis Venture Fund, the corporate venture arm of the Switzerland-based pharmaceutical corporation Novartis. König has been at Novartis for more than 17 years, starting as a strategic assistant to the chairman and CEO, before transitioning into corporate venturing. In 2017, she became global head, overseeing operations across multiple company sites.

Launched in 1996, the Novartis Venture Fund invests in therapeutic and healthcare startups from early through to late stage. The team has \$750m under management and will typically invest around \$30m in a company over its life.

The fund has made more than 130 investments and has 25 active portfolio companies. Recent investments include co-leading the series A funding round

for Mediar Therapeutics, a biotechnology company developing therapies for fibrosis.

Novartis Venture Fund has had 72 successful exits from its portfolio, including 39 companies that have listed on the stock exchange. One of its most notable exits was Forma Therapeutics, a developer of therapies for rare blood disorders, which was bought by Novo Nordisk for \$1.1bn in 2022.

Before joining Novartis Venture Fund in 2006, König was a US-based associate partner at management consultancy firm McKinsey, where she worked with healthcare, pharmaceutical and biotech firms on both sides of the Atlantic.

König is a member of the board of trustees of the Swiss National Science Foundation and an independent board director of Sensirion, a Switzerland-based developer of sensors for manufacturing companies. ■



The fund has made more than 130 investments and has 25 active portfolio companies

David Krane

CEO and managing partner **GV**



David Krane is chief executive and managing partner of GV, US-based technology conglomerate Alphabet's early-stage corporate venturing subsidiary. He manages the fund's activities worldwide.

Krane is responsible for GV backing a number of high-profile businesses that have led to successful exits. These include ride-sharing provider Uber, smart home device maker Nest, and coffee roaster and retailer Blue Bottle Coffee. Other notable exits include a \$3.5bn reverse merger for genetic testing service 23andMe in June 2021, and a deal that saw Illumina acquire Grail, a cancer-testing specialist valued at more than \$7bn, later the same year.

Today, the unit – formerly known as Google Ventures – has more than \$8bn in assets under management and around 400 active portfolio companies. So far in 2023, GV has taken part in

a number of deals including a role in the \$15m series A round for security automation platform Push Security and a lead role in the \$42m series C raise for Clever Care Health Plan, a health insurance specialist.

GV appointed Krane a general partner in 2010, shortly after the unit was created. He became managing partner four years later. Krane took up the joint managing partner and CEO roles in 2016 after Bill Maris, the unit's former head and co-founder, stepped down. Krane was originally hired by Google in 2000.

Before joining Google, Krane spent his time in both startups and public companies, having worked for consumer electronics producer Apple, mobile chipmaker Qualcomm, Four11, which is the predecessor of email service provider Yahoo Mail, and two cybersecurity technology developers. ■



The unit has more than \$8bn in assets under management and around 400 active portfolio companies

Brian Kuwahara

Senior director **Visa Ventures**

Brian Kuwahara was appointed senior director at Visa Ventures, the corporate venturing arm of global payments company Visa, in 2014, having previously spent eight years as the firm's head of technology strategy.

Visa Ventures has a global focus and partners with innovative payments, fintech and technology companies to identify investment opportunities that will give its parent company access to disruptive technologies and emerging themes in the payments sector.

Among the unit's investments are a role in the \$19m series A round for Florida-based fintech firm NovoPayment. It has also made investments in a number of current or former portfolio companies, including GoodData, a business-insight software platform, compliance infrastructure firm Very Good Security and Hive, a provider of AI solutions for understanding

web-based content. More recently, Visa took part in a \$45m series B round for Moov, a startup providing digital wallet and payment technology tools to developers. Visa and Moov partnered up last year to connect the startup with the payment processor's network.

As Visa's head of technology strategy, Kuwahara was responsible for developing the company's approach to innovation, while also helping to integrate acquisitions such as CyberSource, Playspan, Fundamo, GPNet and TrialPay. Between 2014 and 2017, Kuwahara retained responsibility for Visa's emerging technologies operations alongside his role at Visa Ventures.

Before joining Visa, Kuwahara spent more than a decade as a partner at consultant Accenture, specialising in payments, banking and insurance. ■



Visa Ventures has a global focus and partners with payments, fintech and technology companies

David Lee

Executive VP and head **Samsung Next**

Formerly known as Samsung Global Innovation Center, Samsung Next is the early-stage technology investment fund set up by South Korea-headquartered consumer electronics manufacturer Samsung Electronics.

Led by David Lee, the unit focuses on emerging technologies such as artificial intelligence, blockchain, fintech, healthtech, infrastructure, mediatech and robotics. It pursues both strategic investments, merger and acquisition deals and corporate strategy.

Samsung Next has made more than 250 investments. The most recent of these include participation in the \$120m series B round for blockchain messaging protocol developer LayerZero Labs and a role in the \$13m series A round for Mitiga, a cloud-based solution for incident response units.

Other recent additions to the Samsung Next

portfolio include Stability AI, a company that builds open AI tools, and MosaicML, which helps users train and deploy large language models and other generative AI models securely on their data.

Lee joined the unit in February 2021 after more than five years as a managing partner at Refactor Capital, the venture capital firm he set up in 2016 with former Andreessen Horowitz investor Zal Bilimoria. Lee was previously a managing partner at Ron Conway's VC firm, SV Angel.

At Samsung Next, he works with Brendon Kim, the unit's head of investments who has been with the company for more than a decade. Lee holds a master of science in electrical engineering from Stanford University and a JD in law from New York University School of Law. ■



The unit pursues both strategic investments, merger and acquisition deals and corporate strategy

Crispin Leick

Managing director **EnBW New Ventures**



Our aim is to act as an open innovation platform to support entrepreneurs in their endeavour to create game-changing companies

Crispin Leick has more than 15 years of experience in CVC and is the managing director of EnBW New Ventures (ENV), the \$110m corporate venturing unit set up by Germany-headquartered infrastructure utility EnBW in 2016.

ENV is the second major fund Leick has helped to launch, having first raised \$100m for RWE Innogy Venture Capital in early 2008 for Germany-based energy firm RWE's renewable energy subsidiary RWE Innogy.

ENV invests in innovative, fast-growing companies which are driving energy, mobility and urban transformation through scalable business models. He says: "Our aim is to act as an open innovation platform to support entrepreneurs in their endeavour to create game-changing companies." The unit typically acts as the lead or co-investor on deals ranging in size from €1m to €10m.

Among ENV's recent investments are participation in the \$8.5m venture round for Vivacity Labs, the transport technology scaleup transforming cities into smarter and more efficient places to live and work, and a lead role in the €10m series B round for Deepomatic, a visual automation platform that allows companies to enrich reporting and automate the quality control of their operations. ENV also led on the €4m series A round for cloud communications platform babelforce. Other portfolio companies include Easelink, a developer of automated electric vehicle charging technology, and Holo-Light, a business driving augmented reality applications enabling the industrial metaverse.

ENV had three exits in the past 24 months: Replex was bought by Cisco, Lumenaza was bought by financial investors, and DZ4 was entirely taken over by the EnBW corporate. ■

Jacqueline LeSage

Managing general partner **Munich Re Ventures**



LeSage has also been responsible for implementing a corporate structure at MRV that is more supportive of VC investment

Jacqueline LeSage is founder and managing director of Munich Re Ventures (MRV), the strategic investment arm for Germany-listed reinsurance firm Munich Re.

MRV's current areas of focus are climate tech, cybersecurity, industrial equipment and technologies, the future of transportation and insurtech. Since MRV was set up in 2014, LeSage's main focus – in addition to remaining an active investor – has been to develop a strong and stable investment platform for many of the diverse and still emergent approaches that Munich Re takes to accessing innovation.

LeSage has also been responsible for implementing a corporate structure at MRV that is more supportive of venture capital investment. "It was clear we needed to develop a structure that would be adaptable to Munich Re's increasingly direct VC appetite across the

company," says LeSage. This involved creating a separate legal entity under the Munich Re umbrella, with the traditional general partner and limited partner set-up in 2018. The unit then moved its management company into its own legal entity at the start of 2022.

MRV's latest deals include a lead role on the \$14m series A round for space-vehicle developer Starfish Space and participation in the \$25m series B raise for life insurance platform Dayforward. The unit has also backed the \$24m series A round for ShipIn, a visual fleet management system for the maritime industry.

LeSage holds a bachelor of science degree in economics and multinational management from University of Pennsylvania's Wharton School and an MBA from University of Chicago's Booth School of Business. ■

Quinn Li

Senior VP **Qualcomm Ventures**

Quinn Li has run Qualcomm Ventures, US-listed chipmaker Qualcomm's corporate venture capital arm, since 2016. In November 2018, he was additionally promoted from vice president to senior VP for the corporate.

Li has cemented his reputation as a leader in the venture community with a string of deals and initiatives and Qualcomm Ventures now boasts an active global investment portfolio of more than 150 companies, having invested more than \$2bn since being set up in 2000. In that period, the unit has achieved 18 exits from companies valued at \$1bn or more. Li and his team invest in key areas including 5G, artificial intelligence, automotive, enterprise and internet-of-things technology to help expand Qualcomm's ecosystem of customers and partners.

In the past year, the unit has invested

in companies including technology sales platform Humane, remote collaboration developer Absurd:Joy and R-Zero, a biosafety firm. It also took the lead role in the \$15m venture round for cloud robotics and machine learning company Third Wave Automation, and participated in the \$32m series A round for Blues Wireless, a communications equipment business.

Li joined Qualcomm Ventures in 2005 after roles at IBM, Broadcom and Lucent, following completion of his electrical engineering PhD at Washington University in St Louis. He says some of the biggest challenges he has had to overcome involved finding the balance between strategic and financial objectives while building the right team with sufficiently diverse experience to expand investments into new areas. ■



Qualcomm Ventures boasts an active global investment portfolio of more than 150 companies, having invested more than \$2bn

Jeffrey Li

Managing partner **Tencent Investment**

Jeffrey Li serves as managing partner of Tencent Investment and corporate vice president of Tencent. He heads Tencent global initiatives in frontier technology investment and strategic M&A, covering consumer and retail, enterprise service, fintech, social and content, as well as life sciences. Tencent Investment promotes an equal and diversified internet ecosystem with remarkable financial return.

In recent months, Tencent Investment has invested in companies including Rox Motor, a maker of electric off-road vehicles, virtual fitness platform Quell and financial management software developer Aspire. Tencent Investments has also backed insurtech firm Curacel, digital bank Lunar and Oxbotica, a developer of autonomous vehicles.

Li serves as board director in several listed

companies. He was awarded multiple times as top 10 investors by Zero2IPO, top 30 investors by Forbes China and top five corporate investors by Global Corporate Investment Alliance.

Li joined Tencent in 2011 and launched and led Tencent Investment's efforts to penetrate key sectors including automotive, education and healthcare. He was responsible for Tencent's investments in Huayi Brothers, Zhihu, Netmarble Games, Howbuy and many other innovative businesses around the world.

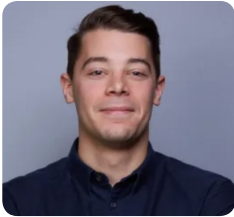
Prior to joining Tencent Investment, Li worked at Google, Nokia and Bertelsmann Asia Investments (now BAI Capital) with extensive experience in technology, the internet and investment. He received a bachelor's degree from Peking University's Guanghua School of Management and an MBA from Duke University's Fuqua School of Management. ■



Tencent Investment promotes an equal and diversified internet ecosystem with remarkable financial return

Brad Lightcap

COO and manager **OpenAI Startup Fund**



Brad Lightcap is in charge of the OpenAI Startup Fund, the \$100m investment fund set up by San Francisco-based AI research outfit OpenAI in 2021. Lightcap joined OpenAI as its chief financial officer in 2018 before moving on to become the firm's chief operating officer in May 2022. It is as COO that he oversees the OpenAI Startup Fund.

The fund's initial portfolio companies, unveiled in December 2022, include AI-driven editing software Descript; Harvey, an AI service for the legal profession; workspace app Mem; and AI-based language training platform Speak.

"We believe there is an enormous amount of value yet to be unlocked for the world with AI," says Lightcap. "We are proud to partner with the talented founders and teams at Descript, Harvey AI, Mem and Speak, as they are building the tools that we believe will have

a significant impact on everything from legal services to language learning, productivity and creative expression."

Microsoft has worked with OpenAI since 2019 when it made an initial \$1bn investment in the company. OpenAI allocated part of that money to set up the OpenAI Startup Fund – in which Microsoft is a co-investor – with the aim of helping AI companies have a "profound, positive impact" on the world. OpenAI co-founder and CEO Sam Altman said the fund was "not a typical corporate venture fund" and that it planned to make "big early bets" on a relatively small number of companies.

Prior to joining OpenAI, Lightcap was an investor at Y Combinator, the US-based startup accelerator, head of strategic finance at cloud-storage firm Dropbox and an investment banking analyst at JP Morgan in New York. ■



We believe there is an enormous amount of value yet to be unlocked for the world with AI

Anthony Lin

Corporate VP and managing partner **Intel Capital**



Anthony Lin took the role as head of Intel Capital, the corporate venturing arm of chipmaker Intel, following Wendell Brooks' departure in mid-2020. Lin, who has been with the company since 2008, was previously in charge of mergers and acquisitions (MA) and international investing.

Since Intel Capital was founded in 1991, it has made more than 1,500 investments in businesses around the world, as well as more than 450 exits, either through IPO or M&A transactions.

Intel Capital invests in innovative technology startups and companies globally and helps portfolio companies leverage the corporate's resources. Over the past 12 months, the unit has been involved as lead investor on a number of deals including a \$23m series A round for Oxos Medical, a developer of medical imaging

devices; a \$20m series A raise for personalised drug treatment platform MDI Health; and the \$15m series A round for Moderne, a computer code-remediation specialist.

In February 2022 the unit launched a \$1bn investment fund with its semiconductor fabrication business, Intel Foundry Services, to foster an innovation ecosystem surrounding fab technology. The fund will back early-stage developers of foundry-related technologies with the potential to help reduce the time to market for Intel Foundry Services' customers, covering areas such as intellectual property, software, innovative semiconductor architectures and advanced packaging.

Before joining Intel, Lin worked for 12 years in corporate finance, M&A and private equity roles at Bank of America Securities, ASAT, Merrill Lynch and PaineWebber. ■



Since Intel Capital was founded in 1991, it has made more than 1,500 investments in businesses around the world

Annabelle Long

Founder and managing partner **Bertelsmann Asia Investments**

Annabelle Long is the founder and managing partner at Bertelsmann Asia Investments (BAI), the China-based corporate venturing arm for Germany-headquartered media group Bertelsmann.

Having joined the unit at its inception in 2008, Long has led her team to achieve more than 17 initial public offerings and has backed 40 companies valued at \$1bn or more. These include supply chain finance company Linklogis, fintech company Lexin and Dingdong Fresh, a fresh vegetable ecommerce platform.

Recent investments include leading the \$10m series A round for RM Group, a developer of technology for the metaverse, and has taken part in seed rounds for collaborative design workspace Fabrie and Meson, a blockchain technology developer.

Bertelsmann has four funds: Bertelsmann

Asia Investments, Bertelsmann Brazil Investments, Bertelsmann India Investments and Bertelsmann Digital Media Investments, the latter focusing on the US and Europe. Through these funds, the company has around 250 shareholdings around the world. The group also has a fund-of-funds strategy in place in Southeast Asia and Africa. However, China has been the most dominant growth region for the organisation. BAI focuses on new media, internet and mobile internet, online education, new technologies, outsourcing and services sectors. In 2022, BAI's spinoff venture capital arm BAI Capital closed its first \$700m fund. It was set up to help its portfolios companies expand in other parts of the world.

Long has an MBA from the Stanford Graduate School of Business and a BSEE from the University of Electronic Science and Technology in China. ■



Long has led her team to achieve more than 17 initial public offerings and has backed 40 companies valued at \$1bn or more

Stéphane Longuet

Managing director **Convivialité Ventures**

Stéphane Longuet is the co-founder and managing director of Convivialité Ventures, the US-based corporate venture capital arm of Pernod Ricard, a France-headquartered liqueur group.

With a team of 10 based in San Francisco, Shanghai, Mumbai and Paris, Convivialité Ventures is also exploring investment opportunities in Southeast Asia, in addition to its existing investments in the US, China, India, Europe, the Middle East and Africa. The CVC unit has invested in household names such as Glovo, Fever and Zola.

Longuet has been with Pernod Ricard for two decades and has helped grow various drinks brands. Before leading Convivialité Ventures, he was the managing director of challenger brands at The Absolut Company and led the integration of Absolut into Pernod Ricard. His

team is now expanding its investment thesis to include more B2B topics such as sales and marketing, sustainability and responsibility.

Longuet sees CVCs as playing the VC game while investing, meaning they should have the same rights as everyone and be good and easy co-investors with VCs. He advises not to force a partnership but to adapt the partnership to the startup's maturity, making it the most beneficial for both the startup and the corporate.

Longuet was tasked with creating the new CVC activity for Pernod Ricard in San Francisco in 2017, investing in B2C startups in the conviviality space. He started by crafting a strategy that could lead to a long-term return on investment, both financially and strategically. Today, Convivialité Ventures continues to build on this strategy, as it expands its investment portfolio to include more B2B startups and increase its fund size. ■



Longuet advises not to force a partnership, but to adapt the partnership to the startup's maturity

Luís Manuel

Executive director **EDP Ventures**



The unit supports and stimulates the open innovation process in the energy sector, challenging our own business units

Luís Manuel has run EDP Ventures, the corporate venturing unit of Portugal-based energy company EDP, as executive director since 2008.

EDP Ventures invests in early-stage tech startups, which are working in the energy sector and are capable of “impacting the lives of millions of people”. The unit says it “supports and stimulates the open innovation process in the energy sector, challenging our own business units to continually look for bold solutions”. It backs companies in areas ranging from green hydrogen and decarbonisation to mobility and renewable power storage technology.

Among EDP Ventures’ recent investments are a lead role in the €4m series A round for APlanet, a Spain-based developer of technology services focused on sustainability, and participation in the £9.2m venture round

for Mixergy, a UK-headquartered renewable power company. The unit also joined the €13m series A round for HySiLabs, a firm which has developed a zero-emissions liquid fuel.

EDP Ventures is just one part of a suite of innovation tools that come under Manuel’s remit of EDP Innovation. He is also responsible for the EDP Starter business incubation programme, the Free Electrons accelerator partnership and EDP’s open innovation programme, as well as running labs and prototyping centres that allow collaboration with the wider community.

Before joining EDP, he worked at Explorer Investments, one of the largest private equity firms in Portugal, as well as for oil and gas company Galp Energia. Earlier in his career, he worked at Espírito Santo Investment in the project finance advisory and corporate finance departments. ■

Dominique Mégret

Head **Swisscom Ventures**



Around half of the capital is being invested in the Swiss ecosystem, while the remainder goes to markets SCV is familiar with

Dominique Mégret has run Swisscom Ventures (SCV), the corporate venture capital arm of telecoms firm Swisscom, since helping to set up the unit in 2005. The fund runs on an evergreen model where returns are reinvested in new portfolio companies.

SCV targets early- to later-stage developers of IT, cloud and communication infrastructure building on the unit’s heritage, in addition to disruptive digital applications covering verticals such as ehealth, fintech, telecoms, ecommerce, egovernment, emobility, energy, precision agriculture, industry 4.0 and digital media.

Around half of the capital is being invested in the Swiss ecosystem, while the remainder goes to markets SCV is familiar with, encompassing the US, Europe and Israel. Initial commitment per deal typically starts at \$1m for seed to early-stage with follow-on

investments of up to \$20m per company. In July 2022, the unit closed its €300m fourth fund, with 75% of the capital coming from external investors.

SCV’s recent investments include a lead role in the €27m series A funding round for in-orbit services provider ClearSpace, as well as participation in the \$21m series B round for Securithings, which develops security systems for connected devices.

Before Mégret joined Swisscom in 2002 he was an entrepreneur in the UK, a strategy consultant in the European telecoms industry, a country manager for a Germany-based IT company and also a co-founder of venture capital firm Kick-Start Ventures.

Mégret has a bachelor’s degree from the European Partnership of Business Schools and an MBA from Insead. ■

Mario Mele

Former VP corporate planning and strategy **Telus Ventures**

Mario Mele ran Telus Ventures from mid-2021, but has recently moved to become vice president, risk management and chief internal auditor at the company.

Telus Ventures invests in a range of areas supporting the Telus strategy, including agtech, consumer goods, supply chain, digital health, global business connectivity, smart cities, internet-of-things and data and telecommunications services.

The investment unit has completed almost 140 investments since it was founded in 2001. With a global mandate, Telus Ventures has more than 60 active portfolio companies around the world, including Canada, the US, Asia, Europe and Israel. It is one of Canada's longest-standing corporate venture capital funds.

Speaking in September 2022, Mele said the unit wanted to expand its international

presence: "We have got a global mandate that is beyond the Canadian borders. We have done investments in many sectors, in the US, UK, Israel, Sweden, Australia and other places and we will continue to look globally at investments."

Among Telus Ventures' recent investments are participation in the \$190m series D round for Miovision, a traffic optimisation business, co-investment in the \$15m series B raise for fleet payment company Car IQ. The unit also joined the \$100m series D round for Swift Navigation, a developer of positioning technology for driver-assistance systems.

Mele moved to Telus in 2015 from telecoms company Vodafone, where he had worked as chief marketing officer in the Czech Republic and Turkey. Prior to that he was head of marketing for Spain-based cable firm Ono, which was later bought by Vodafone in a deal worth \$10m. ■



Telus Ventures has completed almost 140 investments and has more than 60 active portfolio companies around the world

Brandon Middaugh

Senior director **Microsoft Climate Innovation Fund**

Brandon Middaugh is senior director of the Microsoft Climate Innovation Fund, the sustainability-focused investment vehicle set up by US-based software provider Microsoft. She was appointed in March 2020, shortly after the fund was initially announced.

Microsoft pledged \$1bn for the fund as part of a wider goal to achieve carbon neutrality by 2030, and to remove the equivalent of the excess carbon it has emitted since its launch by 2050, through actions that will also involve switching to renewable energy use and electric vehicles across all its campuses.

The fund invests in developers of carbon reduction and removal technology, though the corporate – which already owns venture capital unit M12 – has not set details of a timeframe for that capital, nor how wide the range of its portfolio is likely to be.

So far, the fund has made investments in 26 portfolio companies. Among its most recent deals are a role in the \$30m series B round for private-markets sustainability platform Novata and participation in the \$120m series C raise for Boston Metal, a firm which is developing technology to reduce the carbon footprint of steel production processes.

Before joining the fund, Middaugh spent four years at Microsoft as a senior programme manager, leading its distributed energy strategy as part of the company's energy and sustainability activities. Before moving to Microsoft, she had stints at fuel cell system provider Bloom Energy and as a vice president at energy utility Sun Edison, bookending roles as a venture fellow at impact investing network Investors Circle and an internship at venture capital firm Prelude Ventures. ■



Microsoft pledged \$1bn for the fund as part of a wider goal to achieve carbon neutrality by 2030

Bernhard Mohr

Managing director **Evonik Venture Capital**



With a fund size of €400m, Evonik Venture Capital has made more than 50 investments since inception

Bernhard Mohr joined Germany-listed speciality chemicals provider Evonik Industries in 2012 to set up the corporate venture capital unit, having spent more than two decades in the chemicals and venture capital industries.

With a fund size of €400m, Evonik Venture Capital (EVC) has made more than 50 investments since inception, both direct and fund investments. The scope ranges from early-stage to growth-stage with an investment volume of up to €15m per company. The unit invests in technology leaders in the fields of nutrition and care, smart materials and speciality additives, as well as digital technologies. Mid 2022, EVC launched its €150m Sustainability Tech Fund, which invests in technologies that achieve CO₂ mitigation by reducing and removing emissions and that foster carbon sequestrations.

Among the unit's recent deals are the

participation in the series C round for Allay Therapeutics, a San Francisco-based developer of analgesic products that transform pain management, and the investment in the series C round for Chinese SuperC, a technological leader in graphene materials that increases the range, robustness and charging speed of batteries.

In November 2022, EVC closed its first Japanese investment, providing an undisclosed sum for venture capital firm Global Brain's Fund VIII, which invests in disruptive technologies in biotechnology, food and agriculture, cleantech, new materials and deeptech. "The investment in Global Brain strengthens our footprint in the Asia-Pacific region – Japan is a highly innovative country with a well-developed chemical industry, an interesting research landscape and a flourishing startup scene," says Mohr. ■

Søren Møller

Managing partner **Novo Seeds**



We are in a golden era of innovation. We remain dedicated to company creation and early-stage investment

Søren Møller joined pharmaceutical firm Novo in 2011 as managing investment director of its early-stage corporate venture capital arm, Novo Seeds.

Novo is the fully-owned shareholding subsidiary of the Novo Nordisk Foundation, which was founded in 1923 with corporate interests. Apart from Novo Seeds, Novo also has a venture capital to development-stage fund called Novo Ventures.

Novo Seeds focuses on life sciences technology developers. The unit incubates and backs entrepreneurs through pre-seed grants or equity finance. The unit had two exits in 2022: Syndesi Therapeutics was acquired by AbbVie for up to \$1bn, while BioPhero was bought by FMC Corporation for \$200m. Its recent investments include Engimmune Therapeutics, a developer of T-cell based

therapeutics, and ophthalmic disease specialist Breye Therapeutics.

Commenting on the unit's performance in 2022, Møller said: "We are in a golden era of innovation. We remain dedicated to company creation and early-stage investment as we continue to see an increasing number of exciting investment opportunities, and we do not see it slowing down. In 2022, we accelerated our company building with an expert-run lab that de-risks and validates discoveries before they are assembled into biotech startups."

Before joining Novo Seeds, Møller was a global manager of bioinformatics at biotechnology producer Novozymes. Prior to that, he was vice president of research and development at RNA research firm Exiqon, which went public and was eventually acquired by medical diagnostics technology provider Qiagen in 2016. ■

Shinzo Nakano

President and CEO **Itochu Technology Ventures**

Shinzo Nakano has been president and CEO of Itochu Technology Ventures (ITV), the corporate venture capital offshoot of Japanese trading conglomerate Itochu Corporation, for the past eight years.

He was responsible for setting up the unit in 2000, but returned to another Itochu subsidiary, the Silicon Valley-based Itochu Technology, six years later. After a subsequent stint as the general manager of the IT business department for the parent, he resumed control of Itochu Technology Ventures in 2015.

The investment unit has launched five technology venture funds, the most recent raising \$100m in 2019. ITV says it leverages Itochu Corporation's vast network of industry resources and global market expertise in major industrial sectors to maximise the growth of

portfolio value through sales and new business development support.

It adds: "Our ultimate goal is the financial return from our investments, and our decision to back entrepreneurs is based on future high-growth potential. Our decision-making process enables us to make investments with speed and flexibility in a wide range of fields."

Among the unit's recent deals, it has taken part in the \$26.7m series D round for Funds, a crowdfunding startup and it led a series A raise of undisclosed size for Nabla Mobility, a business that is developing software to help decarbonise the aviation industry. ITV also joined the November 2022 seed round for CollaboGate, a developer of digital-trust systems for cloud-connected devices.

Nakano has a degree in Law from Keio University in Tokyo. ■



Our decision-making process enables us to make investments with speed and flexibility in a wide range of fields

Kei Onishi

CEO and managing director **Yamaha Motor Ventures**

Yamaha Motor Ventures (YMV), the corporate venturing unit of Japan-based industrials conglomerate Yamaha Motor, made two large structural changes to its leadership team at the start of 2022.

Following almost two years as CEO, Jim Aota became chairman of the unit. At the same time, it was announced that Kei Onishi had been promoted to replace Aota as CEO and managing director. Onishi was previously involved in developing and implementing the company-wide digital transformation strategy, as he was well-connected with multiple business units. He said the investment unit's focus was increasingly on sustainability and working to help the parent company transform itself and develop new businesses.

The unit's initial Exploratory Fund was launched with \$100m in 2018. In June 2022,

it added another vehicle to its repertoire with the launch of its \$100m Yamaha Motor Sustainability Fund. It has an early-stage focus and a longer investment horizon. In March this year, the unit announced its \$100m Exploratory Fund II, which will explore areas such as transportation, robotics, data and artificial intelligence, financial and insurance technology, and digital health and wellness.

Its most recent deals include a role in the additional \$15m series A round for Andes, a developer of microbial technology to accelerate crop growth and carbon capture, and participation in the venture round for an innovator in intelligent safeguarding for industrial robot firm Veo Robotics. Other portfolio companies include factory automation unit Rios and Momnt, an embedded lending solution provider. ■



The investment unit's focus was increasingly on sustainability and working to help the parent company transform itself

Tony Palcheck

VP and managing director **Zebra Ventures**



Tony Palcheck is the vice president and managing director of Zebra Ventures, the corporate venturing arm of US mobile computing technology provider Zebra Technologies. His responsibilities include identifying and executing strategic, minority-equity investments in startup firms to accelerate access to new technologies, future markets and developing talent for all Zebra's business units.

Zebra Ventures backs early-stage companies that extend Zebra's vision of empowering enterprise customers to gain operational visibility and make better decision in real time. As well as providing funding, the unit brings deep domain expertise, access to the parent company's technical resources and network to help portfolio companies meet and exceed their growth plans.

Zebra Ventures' focus technologies include automation and robotics, artificial intelligence,

analytics, data capture, mobile computing, augmented reality and device management. The unit works with startups in sectors such as retail, logistics, manufacturing and warehousing, healthcare and field services.

Among Zebra's recent investments are a role in the €50m series C raise for logistics technology firm Plus One Robotics and participation in the \$66m series C round for RightHand Robotics, an ecommerce fulfilment specialist, and investments in autonomous forklift companies, Fox Robotics and Third Wave Automation.

Palcheck joined Zebra in 2014 after spending a decade as managing director of Motorola Solutions Venture Capital, the corporate investment arm of communications equipment producer Motorola Solutions. Motorola spun off its enterprise solutions business to Zebra in 2014 and Palcheck moved with it. ■



As well as providing funding, the units helps portfolio companies meet and exceed their growth plans

YongJung Park

Investment director **Naver Corp**



YongJung Park has been investment director at South Korea-based internet group Naver Corp since June 2018. His responsibilities include leading the firm's venture capital investment activity across early-, expansion- and growth-stages, as well as supporting various other strategic investment initiatives.

Starting as a web portal and search engine in 1999, Naver has since expanded to a number of activities from news and online books to payments. Its investment activities have reflected the company's growing remit. The investment team has backed more than 80 leading venture capital funds, including Sequoia Capital, Lightspeed Venture Partners, Vertex Ventures, Storm Ventures, Tanglin Venture Partners and DST Global. It has also made direct investments in firms such as Pocket FM, an audio entertainment platform,

fashion ecommerce company Brandi and Lunit, a developer of medical AI software.

Among its recent investments are a role with the Mirae Asset-Naver Asia Growth Fund in the \$200m venture round raise for BigBasket, an India-based online grocery operator, and Naver's participation in the \$70m series C round for Bucketplace, which operates home decorating and interior app OHouse. In April 2022, Naver portfolio company SoundHound, a developer of speech-recognition technology, made its debut on the Nasdaq exchange in New York following a SPAC merger with Archimedes Tech SPAC Partners Co.

Before joining Naver, Park was executive director at TheVentures, an early-stage investment firm in South Korea. He has also worked for Colony Capital, a private equity real estate investment firm. ■



The investment team has backed more than 80 leading venture capital funds

Mukaya Panich

CEO and CIO **SCB 10X**

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"My passion is to solve tough problems and help entrepreneurs further their goals," says Mukaya 'Tai' Panich, CEO and CIO of SCB 10X, the digital technology investment arm of Siam Commercial Bank, the largest and oldest bank in Thailand.

Since joining to found SCB 10X in February 2020, Panich has been instrumental in driving the firm's investments in disruptive technology startups, with specific focus on fintech, blockchain infrastructure and artificial intelligence. SCB 10X has made 13 investments in the past 12 months, including new and follow-on funding rounds.

Panich highlights SCB 10X's investment in AI and blockchain startup Together.xyz, a decentralised cloud provider for large language models for AI applications. "Currently, there is high demand for computing power to train large language models for AI," she says. "The company pulls together computing resources from under-utilised GPUs, providing an efficient and cost-effective solution for training AI models, while using blockchain technology to solve efficiencies in payment."

SCB 10X has also incubated and invested in Rakkar Digital, a digital assets custody platform powered by Fireblocks' industry-leading crypto custody technology and network infrastructure. Fireblocks, a portfolio company of SCB 10X, helps institutions store and transfer digital assets safely and securely. Rakkar uses Fireblocks Technology to power its cryptocustody business.

SCB 10X has backed several other companies working on technologies covering blockchain, decentralised finance and AI, including blockchain data analytics platform for web3, Nansen; Talos, provider of institutional trading infrastructure technology for digital assets; and secure cross-chain general messaging protocol Axelar.

"Israel is our largest exposure geographically – we have a strong focus here and have made significant investments," Panich says. "We have also invested heavily in the US and Southeast Asia."

Panich believes the current bear market

presents an opportunity for decentralised finance and web3 projects to focus on building and expanding the ecosystem, while paving the way for future innovations.

Panich's focus on collaborating with startups is evident in SCB 10X's ecosystem-building initiatives, such as SCB 10X DeFi and Web3 Virtual Summit. The summit, now in its fourth year, brings together top crypto and blockchain founders, industry experts and thought leaders from around the globe to discuss the future of decentralised finance and web3.

Other initiatives include SCB 10X's Venture Builder programme, which offers funding to promising entrepreneurs. Startups selected for the programme also receive mentorship, resources and guidance from SCB 10X's extensive network of partners and customers.

A success for the Venture Builder programme is the crypto-asset and portfolio dashboard platform Ape Board, which it incubated in mid 2021. The startup received seed funding from SCB 10X, along with other investors. It was later acquired by blockchain analytics platform Nansen for an undisclosed amount in 2022.

Panich is focused on driving SCB 10X to be the leading regional corporate VC in Southeast Asia, and for SCB 10X to become one of the leading investors in the blockchain and AI sectors globally.

Under her leadership, SCB 10X has strengthened its team including promoting Pailin 'Pie' Vichakul to be chief operating officer and partner of venture capital, and promoting Unnawut 'O' Leepaisalsuwanna as head of Venture Builder.

With more than 15 years of experience in the investment management industry, Panich was portfolio manager at Pictet Asset Management, where she ran a Pan-Asia fund for five years, specialising in investing in publicly listed technology companies in Asia.

Panich has a master's degree in electrical engineering and computer science from MIT and an MBA from Harvard Business School. ■



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Panich is focused on driving SCB 10X to be the leading regional corporate VC in Southeast Asia, and for SCB 10X to become one of the leading investors in the blockchain and AI sectors globally

Vijay Patel

Managing partner **CVS Health Ventures**



Last year was a really large growth year for us in terms of the team, the scope, the deals we were able to execute

Vijay Patel is managing partner and co-founder of CVS Health Ventures, the corporate venturing unit set up by CVS Health in April 2021. He is also vice president of enterprise business development for the parent company.

Patel is responsible for identifying and executing opportunities across the enterprise through strategic partnerships and investments. He joined CVS Health's Boston Digital Innovation Lab in 2015, where he led the company's efforts to develop strategic partnerships with and investments in digital health and technology companies.

Parent company CVS, which began life as a pharmacy chain, recently expanded into areas including health insurance and prescription benefits management and is now exploring primary care. The corporate venture unit is helping to support that transition.

Speaking in February, Patel said: "Last year was a really large growth year for us in terms of the team, the scope and the deals we were able to execute. This year, a lot of it is around how we make sure we are really institutionalised for scale, where we are supporting the companies and helping them through what will be, from a public standpoint, a more challenging market."

He added: "The relevance and interest in a strategic investor has only increased, given some of the dynamics in the capital markets."

Among the unit's recent investments are a role in the \$30m series B round for virtual digestive healthcare company Oshi Health and participation in the \$100m series D round for Carbon Health, a hybrid health care company.

Before joining CVS Health, Patel worked as an investment professional at HIG Growth Partners and Bain Capital. ■

Matt Peterson

Director, corporate development new initiatives **Amazon**



The Climate Pledge Fund invests in companies working on sustainability across sectors such as the circular economy

Matt Peterson has been with Amazon for nearly two decades and has, for the past three-and-a-half years, been the head of new initiatives and its \$2bn Climate Pledge Fund, as well as the \$1bn Industrial Innovation Fund.

The Climate Pledge Fund invests in companies working on sustainability across sectors such as the circular economy, transport and logistics, buildings, food and agtech, manufacturing, materials, as well as energy generation and storage.

Over the past two years, the fund has backed companies including electric take-off and landing aircraft developer Beta Technologies, greenhouse crop developer Hippo Harvest, green ammonia company Amogy and electric vehicle fast-charging infrastructure developer Resilient Power. It also invested in renewable fuels company Infinium, lithium-ion technology

producer Ion Energy and custom-sized package box developer CMC Machinery.

The Industrial Innovation Fund invests in companies seeking to transform logistics, supply chain and fulfilment. Its portfolio includes robotic companies Agility Robotics, Mantic Robotics and Veo Robotics, warehouse automation provider Bionic Hive and computer vision technology provider Flymingo.

Before heading up new initiatives, Peterson was director of advertising for new initiatives. He spent the preceding 10 years in corporate development, working across every business at Amazon, beginning at manager level, before becoming senior manager then director.

At the turn of the millennium, he co-founded an internet company called WarrantyCheck after working at Summit Partners as an associate for two years. ■

Chris Picariello

President **Johnson & Johnson Innovation – JJDC**

Chris Picariello has been president of Johnson & Johnson Innovation – JJDC since 2019. Established by Johnson & Johnson (J&J) in 1973, JJDC was the world's first corporate healthcare venture capital fund. The unit continues its strategic investing mission today, with a focus on delivering meaningful solutions to patients in the areas of medical devices, diagnostics, pharmaceuticals and biotechnology.

JJDC invests in companies at all stages, from seed to series B and beyond. It recently took part in the \$90m series A financing round for Artera, which uses AI to develop customised cancer treatments, as well as the \$15m series C financing of ONL Therapeutics, a vision-protection specialist. It also took a lead role in the \$25m series B financing of medical data-security firm MedCrypt. The unit also formalised its new company creation capabilities in 2021

by dedicating a team which has launched three companies in areas of strategic relevance to J&J (Aliada Therapeutics, Prana Thoracic and Rapport Therapeutics).

JJDC made 50 new and follow-on investments in 2022, while realising four venture exits. It has more than 170 active portfolio companies. Picariello said that although 2022 was challenging, JJDC was able to provide "strong support and leadership" to its portfolio companies. "The hallmark of JJDC is that we will continue to fund compelling innovation where we see an opportunity to transform and enhance patient outcomes despite market challenges," he says.

Picariello was CFO and global head of procurement for the government grants office and project management office for Janssen Research & Development, a J&J subsidiary, before joining the corporate venturing unit. ■



We will continue to fund compelling innovation where we see an opportunity to transform and enhance patient outcomes

Arvind Purushotham

Global head of venture investing **Citi Ventures**

Arvind Purushotham leads the venture investing group at Citi Ventures, the corporate venture capital unit of financial services provider Citi, where he manages corporate venturing initiatives and invests in strategic deals.

Purushotham has been in his role since the start of 2011, during which time Citi Ventures has invested in more than 120 companies. In 2020, he helped the unit launch the Citi Impact Fund to back entrepreneurs in areas such as sustainability, workforce development, financial inclusion and social infrastructure. Notably, the fund has a mandate to back women and minority entrepreneurs.

Among the unit's biggest exits are payments solution provider Square, which had its IPO in 2015, and DocuSign, an information processing company which made its debut on the Nasdaq exchange in 2018. In April 2023, portfolio

company GoHenry, a money-management service for young people, was acquired by Acorns in a deal thought to be worth at least \$250m.

In the past year, Citi Ventures has backed the \$20m series B round for Lexion, an AI-based contract management platform, the \$33m series A raise for AI-powered financial planner Clerkie and the \$51m series E round for InfluxData, an open-source database developer, among other investments.

Before joining Citi, Purushotham spent nearly a decade as managing director at venture capital firm Menlo Ventures. Previously, he was a design engineer and a programme manager at chipmaker Intel Corporation.

Purushotham obtained a master of science in electrical engineering from Case Western Reserve University and an MBA from Harvard Business School. ■



In 2020, he helped launch the Citi Impact Fund to back entrepreneurs in areas such as sustainability and financial inclusion

Dan Reed

Managing director **American Family Ventures**



Reed was a strategy director at American Family and oversaw its first venture investments in 2010

Dan Reed founded American Family Ventures as managing director a decade ago and has retained his position as leader as it has grown in size and expanded to take on additional investors.

The firm was formally launched as US-based insurance provider American Family's strategic investment arm in 2013. It took on external limited partners for its most recent funds and now counts insurers with some \$35bn in annual premiums among its backers, while maintaining its focus on bringing the 'insurance carrier perspective' to startups.

Reed was a strategy director at American Family and oversaw its first venture investments in 2010, having previously been a strategy consultant with Boston Consulting Group. Go back further and you will see a career that began with sharpening a competitive edge in professional baseball as a minor league pitcher.

American Family Ventures has expanded over the years to become a 22-strong team and Reed has been joined by three more managing directors – Kyle Beatty in 2018, Katelyn Johnson in 2020 and Brittany Clements last year – who have brought expertise in areas including fintech, ecommerce, data analytics, enterprise software and property technology.

The firm accordingly invests across a range of areas. Some of its most prominent historic exits have been through home and consumer-focused offerings such as Ring, Life360 and, last August, Vesper, but its biggest deals over the past year have been in more core areas: SME-focused health insurance provider Sana and bundled insurance unicorn Branch.

Reed has a BA from Stanford University and an MBA in strategic management from University of Chicago. ■

Madison Rezaei

VP of new business strategy and head **Verizon Ventures**



At the time of her appointment, Verizon said the move would bring the unit closer to the company's corporate strategy

Madison Rezaei was appointed to head Verizon Ventures, the corporate venturing unit of US-based telecommunications company Verizon, in January this year, just two years after joining the company in a business development capacity.

This year alone, it has backed four companies: text message engagement platform Community, 5G radio access network developer Verana Networks, VR technology developer for education Dreamscape Learn and Nami, an artificial intelligence platform for internet of things.

The unit has also seen through successful exits of companies such as fantasy sports company Fanduel (Flutter Entertainment), TV advertising company Invidi (AT&T), and predictive analytics company Medio (Nokia).

Verizon Ventures' other companies include data analytics company Civis Analytics, collision avoidance technology company Iris, insurtech

provider Voom and Aifi, an artificial intelligence platform for autonomous shopping.

On top of its direct investments, Verizon Ventures has secondary investments, such as BBG Ventures, a seed-stage fund focused on women-led tech companies.

At the time of her appointment, along with that of chief investment officer John Nitti, Verizon said the moves would bring the unit closer to the company's corporate strategy.

Before she moved to Verizon in 2020, she advised companies in the technology, media and telecom sectors – across subjects such as digital media, enterprise tech and wireless telecommunications – at consultancy firm Altman Solomon, where she served as director. During her tenure there, she led the Women in Technology group, as well as the firm's pro bono practice. ■

Brad Robling

Vice president **Lilly New Ventures**

Brad Robling has been vice president of Lilly New Ventures, the corporate venturing unit of US-based pharmaceutical firm Eli Lilly, since July 2020. He previously worked as the company's head of corporate business development and investor relations.

Over the past two decades, Lilly New Ventures has been responsible – alongside its partner organisations Chorus and Lilly Gateway Labs – for committing more than \$2bn to early-stage biotech businesses. Lilly's investment philosophy is to take "smart risks on bold science", with a remit that covers life science investments all over the world. The company boasts "a proven legacy of successfully funding, developing, and accelerating innovation to serve patients".

Lilly New Ventures' portfolio includes innovative companies covering core-therapeutic areas, as well as science and technologies

outside Eli Lilly's core focus. Among its recent exits is the sale of US-based portfolio company Nimbus Therapeutics to Japanese pharmaceutical firm Takeda for an undisclosed sum.

Robling has a board position with Sitryx Therapeutics, which focuses on regulating cell metabolism to develop disease-modifying therapeutics. Lilly took a \$10m stake in Sitryx in 2020, while also paying \$50m for a five-year licensing deal for four of the company's drugs. Furthermore, he serves as a board observer on three other innovative companies.

Before joining Eli Lilly in 2012, Robling was director of corporate development at Applied Materials in Santa Clara, California. Prior to that role, he spent the first 10 years of his career at professional services firms Ernst & Young and Deloitte Consulting, as well as in leadership positions at two Silicon Valley startups. ■



The company boasts a proven legacy of successfully funding, developing, and accelerating innovation to serve patients

Gabriela Ruggeri

Managing partner **Kamay Ventures**

Gabriela Ruggeri joined Kamay Ventures, when it was founded in March 2019. The unit invests on behalf of Argentina-headquartered food, agribusiness and packaging conglomerate Arcor and beverage producer Coca-Cola's Argentine subsidiary, Coca-Cola Argentina.

She was previously business development director for UK-based publisher Daily Mail and General Trust International for Latin America. Ruggeri combines her role at Kamay with a managing partner position at Overboost.

The unit is run as a trust fund, operating from Buenos Aires, but investing in startups based in countries across Latin America. At the time of Kamay Ventures' launch, Arcor president Luis Pagani said: "Kamay Ventures will finance projects with a digital focus that intend to improve the lives of people

through innovations in various sectors. The partnership's value for the entrepreneurs will be the support system – experts from the two corporates will act as mentors in areas such as marketing, sales, communication, human resources, logistics, administration and legal matters, thereby enhancing their projects at the regional level."

Kamay Ventures has 11 companies in its portfolio, including US recycling technology company Arqlite, which has raised \$2.6m in funding, and the Mexico-based formal credit support platform Altscore, which has raised \$1.9m with investment from Techstars Boulder Accelerator. Among its recent investments are a role in the seed round for restaurant technology provider Bacu and participation in the venture round for Kilimo, a water-management data business. ■



Kamay Ventures will finance projects with a digital focus that intend to improve the lives of people through innovations

Douglas Russell

Managing director and head **MassMutual Ventures**



MMV backs founders and companies that are fundamentally transforming the industries within our investment focus

Douglas Russell has been the head and managing director of MassMutual Ventures (MMV), the corporate venturing unit of US-based insurance provider Massachusetts Mutual Life Insurance, since 2014.

MMV invests in financial, cybersecurity and digital health technology developers, as well as enterprise software providers, participating in early- and growth-stage rounds. It has made 66 investments and realised 10 exits, the latter have included the sale of enterprise security company Recorded Future to private equity firm Insight Partners in 2019, as well as the acquisition of Even Financial, a search engine for financial services, by mobile banking platform Money Lion in late 2021.

In June 2022, the investment unit launched a \$100m fund aimed at investing in North America and Israel, bringing the total capital

managed by the US-Israel team to \$400m. At the time, Russell said: "This latest fund allows our US team to build on the success and momentum the MMV fund family has realised in backing founders and companies that are fundamentally transforming the industries within our investment focus." The unit has a separate team which focuses on investments in Europe and the Asia-Pacific region.

The unit's recent deals include a lead role in the \$5m series C round for Zylo, a developer of human resources software, and participation in the \$5m series A raise for Accelex, a data business serving the asset-management industry.

Before heading the company's corporate venturing unit, Russell worked for MassMutual Financial for almost a decade, initially as CFO of the retirement income division and then as head of strategy and corporate development. ■

Nicolas Sauvage

President **TDK Ventures**



Our exploration mission is about looking at what could disrupt TDK and make sure we understand it early enough

Nicolas Sauvage founded TDK Ventures in 2019 to help parent company, Japan-headquartered TDK, stay in touch with technological disruptions.

"Our exploration mission is about looking at what could disrupt TDK and make sure we understand it early enough," he says. "Developing a new product from scratch takes probably five years, so you need to see these disruptions five to seven years in advance if you want to be first to market."

TDK Ventures recently launched a third, \$150m fund, bringing its total capital under management to \$350m. It is the first fund in which TDK Ventures has brought in an external investor, Amperex Technology. TDK Ventures also opened an office in India in February.

The team has grown to 25 team members, arranged in what Sauvage terms a "full stack" for venture. That means ten people focused

on investments, another group who work on engagement between the startups and TDK, and a "scaling team" who help portfolio companies grow.

"No other CVCs or VCs that I know of have this three-team combination," says Sauvage.

TDK has so far invested in 29 startups. Recent investments include backing the \$15.2m series A round of Novalith, an Australian lithium mining startup, and co-leading the \$29m fundraising for US fusion startup Type One Energy.

Sauvage is originally an engineer by training, with a degree from the ISEN Engineering School in France, as well as a master's degree from King's College London. He also participated in the executive program at Stanford University's Graduate School of Business, and was awarded the Corporate Director Certificate from Harvard Business School. ■

Yuko Sasahara Watanabe

President and CEO **NTT Docomo Ventures**

Yuko Sasahara Watanabe became president and CEO of NTT Docomo Ventures, the corporate venture capital arm of Japan-based telecommunication firm NTT Group's mobile network subsidiary, NTT Docomo, in June 2021.

Sasahara Watanabe took control of the unit from Takayuki Inagawa – himself a GCV Powerlist award winner in 2020 – after he was promoted to general manager and head of the innovation management department for NTT Docomo.

Previously, Sasahara Watanabe was responsible for co-creating new innovative businesses with entrepreneurs through NTT Docomo's 39works programme. She also worked in the company as a product and service design specialist and co-developed the concept and technical specifications of i-mode service, an internet-based service for mobile phones, which was originally launched in 1999.

NTT Docomo Ventures was founded in 2008 and has invested in almost 170 companies in a bid to accelerate innovation on behalf of the NTT Group. It seeks cooperation opportunities with entrepreneurs globally by providing capital from its CVC vehicles and business development initiatives with NTT's group companies.

Recent investments that NTT Docomo Ventures has participated in include the ¥5.4bn (\$40m) series B round for knowledge engine Baseconnect Japan, and the \$66m series D raise for Sitetracker, a critical infrastructure platform. It has also invested in big data platform RapidSOS, which raised \$75m in a round that also included Honeywell, Microsoft's M12 Fund and Citi's Impact Fund.

Sasahara Watanabe has an MBA from the Sloan Fellows Program at Massachusetts Institute of Technology. ■



The unit has invested in almost 170 companies in a bid to accelerate innovation on behalf of the NTT Group

Jaidev Shergill

SVP and head **Capital One Ventures**

Since 2014, Jaidev Shergill has run Capital One Ventures, the corporate venture capital arm of US-based financial services firm Capital One.

The unit is a multi-stage, strategic investor focused on technology, data and financial services. It is involved in investments, acquisition identification, technology and business partnerships, startup incubation and collaboration with venture capital and venture studios.

Most recently, Capital One Ventures funded Securiti.ai, a company focused on unified data controls, Observe, which provides enterprise data monitoring for site reliability engineers and Harness, a software delivery platform. It also led the \$96m venture round for travel service Hopper, participated in the \$20m series C round for OvationCXM, a customer experience management platform, and participated in the \$38m series B round in Evincel, which provides

accessibility testing tools for developers. The unit has invested in more than 70 companies, including data cloud platform Snowflake, as well as Eightfold and Code Signal which incorporate AI and ML to match talent based on skill and potential.

Shergill says embedded finance is becoming an investment focus: "We are seeing a convergence where financial services are increasingly embedded into ecommerce and other software platforms."

Shergill joined Capital One in 2013 through the acquisition of Bundle, a startup he founded that leveraged behavioural and economic data to rate small businesses. Prior to starting Bundle, he was president of the venture capital investing practice at Citigroup, now known as Citi Ventures. He started his career as a management consultant at Deloitte and FMCG Direct. ■



We are seeing a convergence where financial services are embedded into ecommerce and other software platforms

Brian Schettler

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Partner and head **AEI HorizonX**



Even before heading up venture investments for Boeing, working in aerospace and defence was Brian Schettler's expertise from the beginning.

He started his career as an electrical engineer designing and building aerospace products. From university, he started his career at Northrop Grumman designing and building aerospace products. He spent the next decade-and-a-half working across a variety of corporate strategy, investment and corporate and portfolio development roles in aerospace and defence companies such as ATK, Cobham and Boeing – where he worked an initial stretch in its defence research and development arm, Phantom Works.

It eventually dawned on Schettler that what can be done with internal resources was not the be-all and end-all of innovation – the external innovation ecosystem can also be leveraged to powerful strategic effect. “What I started pushing on, even back then before corporate venturing was a big thing, was how does a partnership with a big corporate work with the venture community and how we could do more together,” says Schettler.

His return to Boeing in 2017 came at a time when Boeing's business was in great shape: its revenues were nearing a 10-year peak and management was more conscious of potential disruption from outside innovation. This provided fertile ground for the formation of HorizonX, Boeing's internal venturing unit, which spent the next four years investing in companies such as EP Systems (aerospace battery systems), Immfly (in-flight entertainment and connectivity software) and AI solutions provider, SparkCognition.

From the beginning it was clear that the mandate did not end with financial returns – it wanted to bring tangible strategic benefits to the parent. “That is really where the rubber meets the road on how you derive the value from the global corporate venturing activities. We spent a lot of time getting that right. It is a cultural element, it

is an organisational element, it is process steps, it is managing expectations, and then it is actually executing,” says Schettler.

“It took some time, but we really stood up a great capability inside Boeing to realise the value of the technologies in which we were investing.”

When the situation in Boeing began to change towards the end of the 2010s, with the compounding crises of the covid pandemic and the 737 Max impacting Boeing's bottom line, Schettler realised that difficult decisions would need to be made in the company. Knowing that there was a needle that had to be threaded delicately, he began exploring ways to reposition the internal investment unit. Spinning out became the most attractive option that would enable HorizonX to thrive.

Schettler began searching for a suitable firm to partner with, one that had both financial heft and sector knowledge. The big leviathans were considered, but a dream fit appeared in 2021 with AE Industrial Partners, an aerospace and defence private equity firm.

The switch may have been borne out of a crisis, but for AEI HorizonX it has also been a boon. The investment fund has access to more capital than it had when it was relying solely on Boeing's balance sheet. It can broaden its focus and bring in more financial returns, offer more to its team and count on the deep investment expertise of its partner, while maintaining strong links to Boeing.

Since spinning out, AEI HorizonX has backed companies such as Second Front Systems – a platform to help defence-orientated software startups move through the complicated government approval process – as well as operational technology cybersecurity company Shift5, and next-generation space solar power provider Solestial.

Whatever the airborne version of an iceberg is, Schettler and his team successfully avoided it and emerged larger and faster on the other side. ■



What I started pushing on, even back then before corporate venturing was a big thing, was how does a partnership with a big corporate work with the venture community and how we could do more together

Raj Singh

Managing partner **JLL Spark**

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More so than at any time in the past, real estate is ripe for disruption, following a pandemic that forced many people to stay away from the office, and some now choosing not to come back. So, what to do with all that space and how to configure it to deal with remote workforces? That is one of the questions that will now shape the form of large office spaces.

The frontlines of the evolving commercial real estate and proptech markets is the latest post for Raj Singh, a venture capital industry veteran of more than 20 years.

He previously spent five years as managing director at the then-named JetBlue Technology Ventures, following previous investing stints at Pervasive Technology Ventures and Investcorp International. He took a five-year break from venturing between 2010 and 2015, when he headed up an innovation-focused consulting firm and then a business services marketplace.

Despite the many years he has worked in innovation and venture investing, Singh says the constantly changing technological landscape is more than enough to keep him interested. Although real estate is one of the industries that has so far avoided the brunt of digital disruption, technology changes are beginning to creep into the sector and Singh believes it will not be long until it hits it head on.

"I am motivated because I am convinced that technology will eat commercial real estate, and I want my organisation to not only survive that, but to ride that wave. In every other industry that has happened, and that is coming for us," he says.

Working with startups specifically is something he enjoys doing, particularly in an industry such as real estate. The consistent success of the real estate sector over a long period of time has meant that many companies tend to rest on their laurels and have become too comfortable, without needing to innovate. In this context, it becomes crucial to find the creative thinkers and industry disrupters that are pushing the real estate industry forward.

"I believe that those people who make strange and unusual predictions about the future often turn out to be right," he says.

"I like the engagement with those people. I like learning and seeing a different perspective because I know that I and everybody else who have been in an industry for a while can often get complacent. You just accept and believe certain things which are not necessarily true. They are just the way that things have been done in the past."

The market may be in a downturn, but Singh believes it would be a mistake for investors to stop deploying capital. It would leave a gap in the portfolio, which will remain as a fallow period for returns even after the market goes back on an upswing. This is true of both financial and strategic returns.

JLL Spark has continued to invest in 2023, with recent investments including backing the \$90m series B funding round for Infogrid, the maker of a sustainability-focused smart building platform.

For entrepreneurs this is a great time to start a company if you keep it small, lean and without great expectations of getting revenue right away, says Singh. He advises young startups to think about how to get themselves into a position to make the most of the eventual upturn. If you are not at a position where you have recurring revenue, he says, then focus on putting all the pieces in place to come out swinging when things are looking up again.

"How do I redirect my products such that when the market comes back, I am in prime position to go out there and disrupt? It is less about revenue now, more about building," says Singh.

For slightly more mature startups, however, this is a time to be more conservative and for survival mode. Getting through this macroeconomic rough patch likely means having to come down on the burn rates, which will be painful but necessary. "Focus on renewing your current customers and adding value to the product," says Singh. ■



“

I am motivated because I am convinced that technology will eat commercial real estate, and I want my organisation to not only survive that, but to ride that wave. In every other industry that has happened, and that is coming for us

Shreyansh Singh

Head of investments **Polygon Technology**



Polygon Technology has emerged as one of the most prolific investors in the Web3 sector, with more than 100 investments

Shreyansh Singh is head of investments at Polygon Technology, the corporate venturing unit set up by US-based web3 infrastructure company Polygon Labs. Before taking his role at Polygon Technology, Singh was head of another of the firm's subsidiaries, Polygon Studios, which focused on developing an NFT (non-fungible token) ecosystem and creating gaming projects, particularly in the metaverse.

Polygon Technology has emerged as one of the most prolific investors in the web3 sector, with more than 100 investments since it was founded. Like many of its blockchain-focused peers, it invests broadly to help build up an ecosystem around its platform. The team makes early-stage investments – mainly seed rounds – across all categories of web3.

Among Polygon Technology's recent investments are a lead role in the \$2.8m seed

round for PolyTrade, a blockchain-based trade finance platform, and involvement in the \$3m seed round for metaverse technology developer Anima. The unit also joined the \$4m pre-seed round for collaborative creativity community Stems Labs and the \$40m series A raise for cryptocurrency platform MPCH Labs.

Singh, who is based in Dubai, joined Polygon Labs – initially known as Matic Network when it was set up in 2017 – as its marketing lead four years ago. Matic Network rebranded as Polygon in February 2021 “to better reflect its goal of bringing multiple Ethereum-compatible scaling solutions to web3”. Polygon was designed to be “the first well-structured, easy-to-use platform for Ethereum scaling and infrastructure development”. The company brought its various operations under the single Polygon Labs rebrand at the start of 2023. ■

Yat Siu

Chairman and co-founder **Animoca Brands**



We are pleased to see continued and growing support from influential and strategic investors for Animoca Brands' mission

Animoca Brands is a Hong Kong-based developer and publisher of video games and blockchain technology with a strong focus on venture investment. Set up in 2015 as a spin-out from smartphone app developer Animoca, the unit is led by Yat Siu, a long-time technology entrepreneur and investor.

Animoca Brands was one of the world's most active corporate investors last year, with involvement in almost 130 deals. Among the investments carried out by the firm in 2023 are a role in the \$10m seed round for digital finance specialist Galactic Holdings and participation in the \$3m series B raise for LandVault, a monetisation platform for in-game advertising. Animoca Brands has made more than 250 investments and has had 12 exits, including games publisher iCandy Interactive.

In 2022, as Animoca Brands announced its

own \$359m funding round, Siu said: “We are pleased to see continued and growing support from influential and strategic investors for Animoca Brands' mission to deliver true digital property rights and build the open metaverse.

“We have set ourselves the ambitious goals of building an open web3 and facilitating an open metaverse that expands financial inclusion. In 2021, we saw tremendous growth in this space and Animoca Brands has been one of the forefront leaders in the development of this industry.”

Siu began his career at Atari Germany in the early 1990s before moving to Hong Kong to establish Outblaze, a social media and messaging service developer. In 2009, part of Outblaze was sold to IBM with the remaining business becoming an incubator for entrepreneurs and companies in digital entertainment – one of which became Animoca. ■

Jeffery Smith

Director, equity and venture capital **Bristol Myers Squibb**

Jeffery Smith became director of the equity and venture capital operations at biopharmaceutical company Bristol Myers Squibb in March 2021, having joined the firm from Roth Capital Partners, a private banking firm.

His role at Bristol Myers Squibb involves supporting the company's efforts in partnering with the innovative, science and technologies at external businesses with the company's own capabilities and expertise.

Describing its venturing operations, Bristol Myers Squibb says: "We seek to combine external innovative science and technologies with our internal capabilities and expertise to transform patients' lives through science. We are active across the entire business development spectrum and all our collaborations are essential to evolving our portfolio and driving our long-term sustainability."

Among the company's recent deals are a role in the \$158m series B raise for TORL BioTherapeutics, a clinical-stage biopharma business, and participation in the \$25m series A round for Outpace Bio, a developer of smart cell therapies. The unit also joined a series A round for Mediar Therapeutics, which raised \$85m for fibrosis-treatment specialist.

Other portfolio companies include Century Therapeutics, a developer of allogeneic living drugs created to offer treatment for cancer patients, which successfully closed an IPO on the Nasdaq Global Select Market in June 2021, and Metagenomi, a specialist in genome-editing systems.

Smith has a PhD in cancer biology from the Gerstner Sloan Kettering Graduate School of Biomedical Sciences in New York. ■



We seek to combine external innovative science and technologies with our internal capabilities and expertise

Jon Soberg

CEO and managing partner **MS&AD Ventures**

Jon Soberg is CEO of MS&AD Ventures, the overseas corporate venturing subsidiary of Japan-based insurance firm MS&AD Holdings. He is also the unit's managing partner, a position he held jointly with founder Tak Sato until the latter stepped back in March 2023 to take an advisory role.

MS&AD Ventures was set up in 2018 as the parent company's first overseas corporate venture capital unit, a year after Sato moved to Silicon Valley as the first representative of MS&AD Insurance Group. The unit focuses on early-stage AI, big data, cybersecurity, insurance and internet-of-things technology developers. It has backed almost 90 investments to date and achieved exits on eight portfolio companies, including autonomous vehicle developer Voyage, which was bought by carmaker General Motors' Cruise subsidiary in 2021.

Among MS&AD Ventures' recent investments are a role in the \$4m seed round for web3 communications system EtherMail and participation in the \$42.5m series B raise for Assured Allies, a developer of technology aimed at promoting healthy aging.

Soberg was brought on board by MS&AD Ventures in October 2018, having been a venture capitalist for a decade with a track record of returns including multiple unicorn investments and strong exits. He is known for being among the first cohort of investors from Silicon Valley to invest globally and for his focus on financial technologies and applying data and analytics to change industries.

Soberg graduated as a Palmer Scholar with an MBA in entrepreneurial management and marketing from Wharton, and he holds the Chartered Financial Analyst designation. ■



Soberg was among the first cohort of investors from Silicon Valley to invest globally

John Somorjai

EVP of corporate development **Salesforce Ventures**



The unit has invested more than \$5bn and partnered with more than 400 enterprise technology companies

Salesforce Ventures, the global investment arm of US-based enterprise software producer Salesforce, is among the most active corporate venture capital units, according to GCV data.

Led by John Somorjai since 2014, the unit has invested more than \$5bn and partnered with more than 400 enterprise technology companies since it was formed in 2009. These include Databricks, DocuSign, Hopin, nCino, Snowflake, Tanium, Twilio and Zoom. The firm has more than 100 acquisitions and 30 IPOs. A number of portfolio companies, including integration platform developer MuleSoft and digital transformation software producer Vlocity, have gone on to be acquired by the unit's parent company.

In March 2023, Salesforce Ventures launched a \$250m generative AI fund. The announcement of the fund came as Salesforce unveiled the

latest version of its AI technology, Einstein GPT, which can be combined with large-language models such as ChatGPT to create personalised content for sales, marketing or code generation.

The fund disclosed four investments at launch: AI safety and research provider Anthropic, natural language processing startup Cohere, decision-making tool developer Hearth AI and You.com, which offers an AI-based search engine.

Somorjai was initially tasked with deploying the unit's \$100m Salesforce1 Fund. He then brought in Matt Garratt, a GCV Rising Star 2016, to run what became Salesforce Ventures in October that year and it quickly grew.

Somorjai previously worked in business development at both pay-per-call company Ingenio, which was acquired by AT&T, and Oracle Corporation. ■

Laela Sturdy

Managing partner **CapitalG**



To date, CapitalG has invested more than \$4bn, often deploying \$100m or more per transaction

With a portfolio that includes the likes of payment processor Stripe, human resources platform Gusto and data analytics company Databricks, heading up Alphabet's growth fund is a varied and challenging brief, one that Laela Sturdy assumed earlier this year, having worked at the unit for nearly a decade. Consumer and enterprise technology has been the name of the game at CapitalG, and it has made solid work of it.

To date, CapitalG has invested more than \$4bn, often deploying \$100m or more per transaction. At first glance, those big tickets might suggest these are not venture plays anymore, but a defining aspect of CVC is the amount of help the corporate can bring to bear – and judging by the circa 3,000 “Googlers” that have advised CapitalG's portfolio companies, it fits into that mould.

Its current portfolio is impressive, but its

exits – of which there have been 16 IPOs and nine M&A transactions – may be even more so. Short-term rental company Airbnb, cybersecurity firm CrowdStrike, ride-sharing app Lyft, language learning platform Duolingo and social media platform Snap are just a few of the companies formerly on the books – and those are just the ones that exited via public markets. Hiring platform Glassdoor and fantasy sports company Fanduel are among the others that were exited privately.

Sturdy has sat on the boards of many CapitalG portfolio companies, including Glassdoor, credit score provider Credit Karma and Duolingo.

She has a BA in biochemistry from Harvard University, as well as a master's in computer science and multimedia systems from Trinity College Dublin and her MBA from Stanford University. ■

Matt Sueoka

Global head **Amex Ventures**

Matt Sueoka took control of US-based payment processing firm American Express's corporate venture capital arm, American Express Ventures, at the end of 2021, following the retirement of Harshul Sanghi.

Until that point, Sanghi had led the unit, which is also known as Amex Ventures, since it was founded in 2011. Amex Ventures plays a central role in driving innovation for American Express. Over the past decade it has backed more than 70 startups, developing technologies and products in commerce, payments, fraud prevention, data analytics and security. Its portfolio is valued at more than \$1bn.

Among its recent deals are a role in the \$53m series D round for small business operation platform Odeko and participation in the \$15m series B round for Rock The Bells, an online retailer of hip-hop merchandise.

Sueoka's previous role was head of global strategy, partnerships and enablement for the Amex Digital Labs innovation team at American Express. In this role, he worked with thought leaders, customers and partners across the globe to catalyse digital innovation at Amex by originating, incubating and managing emerging products and platforms.

Discussing his leadership of Amex Ventures, Sueoka says: "From a historical standpoint, we have built an incredible portfolio, including some of the best companies across fintech, consumer, B2B and enterprise capabilities. We will continue our focus in those spaces, as well as look into the many new opportunities within the web3 space."

Sueoka was a strategy consultant at Bain & Company, where he focused on advising financial services and private equity clients. ■



We have built an incredible portfolio, including some of the best companies across fintech, consumer and B2B

Pradeep Tagare

Head of corporate venture investing **National Grid Partners**

Pradeep Tagare is head of corporate venture investing at National Grid Partners, the investment arm of UK-based utility National Grid. The unit manages a venture capital fund set up in 2018 with \$250m, to which the parent company committed an additional \$150m in April 2021. National Grid Partners has invested in around 40 companies, collaborating with startups at varying stages of development and splitting its partnerships between energy and technology businesses.

Lisa Lambert, founder and president of National Grid Partners, says: "We are investing in and deploying technologies across National Grid's networks to enhance resilience and reliability, while more easily integrating renewable energy. Our company's ambition is to become the most intelligent, cleanest transmission and distribution network in the world."

National Grid Partners has been a lead investor in most deals it has been involved with, and more than 70% of its portfolio companies have strategic engagements with National Grid. The venture unit's main investments focus on the internet-of-things and grid modernisation, cloud computing, artificial intelligence and analytics, security and energy management.

Among its recent investments are its participation in the \$26m series B raise for climate change risk analytics firm Risilience. It also played a lead role in a venture round of undisclosed size for Visionary.ai, an image-signal processing specialist.

Based in California, Tagare joined National Grid Partners in 2018 after spending most of the previous decade as investment director at Intel Capital India. He has a master's degree from University of Wisconsin-Madison. ■



More than 70% of its portfolio companies have strategic engagements with National Grid

William Taranto

President and general partner **Merck Global Health Innovation Fund**



Under Tarantino's leadership, MGHIF has invested more than \$1bn in 70 companies, with more than \$7bn in exits

William Taranto is president of both Merck Global Health Innovation Fund (MGHIF), and Merck Global Health Private Equity (GHIPE). He is the founder of MGHIF and is responsible for leading the global health capability for Merck.

The Merck Global Health Innovation Fund was established in late 2010 as a strategic response to the challenges surrounding Merck's core business of discovering, developing and marketing innovative drugs and vaccines. Taranto has more than three decades of experience in the healthcare industry.

MGHIF is a \$500m evergreen fund focused on identifying opportunities that are adjacent to Merck's core business of pharmaceuticals and vaccines. Under Taranto's leadership, MGHIF has invested more than \$1bn in 70 companies, with more than \$7bn in exits.

The unit's recent deals include participation

in the pre-seed round for blockchain-based genomics company IndyGeneUS AI and roles as lead investor on both the \$3m venture round for TransVoyant, a developer of digital supply chain services, and the €20m series A round for cancer therapeutics firm Turbine. Other notable investments include PathAI, M2GEN, Navigating Cancer, Syapse, Strata, Precise DX, Trinetx, and Cleardata. Recent unicorn exits include Livongo Health, Preventice Solutions, Ciox and Absci.

Prior to joining Merck, Taranto spent 18 years at Johnson & Johnson (J&J) in various roles. As VP of healthcare strategy and venture at J&J, he was responsible for evaluating and creating new healthcare business models through venture capital and acquisitions. Prior to joining J&J, Taranto spent eight years in investment banking. ■

Ulrich Thiem

Managing director **Porsche Ventures**



The 17-person team manages a portfolio of around 35 active investments, and has had six exits

Ulrich Thiem has been managing director of Porsche Ventures, the corporate venturing unit of German car manufacturer Porsche, since 2019. Having joined the automaker in 2011, he worked in the legal department and as director with responsibility for corporate affairs and investments before taking the reins at Porsche Ventures.

The unit was set up in 2016 and is headquartered in Stuttgart, with offices elsewhere in Europe, as well as in Israel, China and Silicon Valley.

Porsche Ventures has recently moved to having two, tailored investment portfolios. One is close to Porsche's core business, investing mainly in the series B round of startups working on autotech, as well as technology related to intelligent enterprise and sustainability. A second portfolio explores

areas beyond the core business, such as smart cities and industrial solutions.

The 17-person team manages a portfolio of around 35 active investments, and has had six exits, including the sale of RepairSmith, a mobile car repair service, to AutoNation at the end of 2022.

Recent investments by the unit include backing the \$63m series A round for German electric vehicle battery maker Customcells, which is looking to make batteries that are suitable for electric aeroplanes, as well as for cars. It also took part in the \$12.3m series A round for Carputty, a startup which aims to modernise car finance and ownership.

Before joining Porsche, Thiem worked as a corporate lawyer for the CMS legal practice in Frankfurt. He has a PhD in law from Universität Osnabrück in Lower Saxony. ■

Gen Tsuchikawa

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CEO and chief investment officer **Sony Ventures Corporation**

Gen Tsuchikawa is chief executive and chief investment officer of Sony Ventures, which was first established in 2016. Its first fund, the Sony Innovation Fund, was focused on early-stage technologies and was funded from Sony's balance sheet. Tsuchikawa, a long-term veteran of the Japan-headquartered technology conglomerate, had previously been running the group's mergers and acquisitions and had little experience of startup investing.

Seven years later, Tsuchikawa and his team has made more than 150 investments. The organisation has become so successful with his approach that Sony Ventures launched a third fund in February, Sony Innovation Fund 3 (SIF3), which brings in external companies as limited partners. This ¥26.5bn (\$209m) fund includes Mitsubishi Real Estate, Kawasaki Heavy Industry and Koei-Tecmo as investors.

Sony had already tried a more independent structure with its second fund, Innovation Growth Fund, which is run as a joint venture with Daiwa Securities, the Japanese financial institution, and invests in mid-to-late-stage companies. But with the new SIF3 fund, Sony Ventures is going fully into a GP/LP structure on its own.

"In a sense, we are going beyond the CVC definition and doing the fund business," says Tsuchikawa. With this comes an increased pressure to generate financial returns, as well as strategic ones, he says.

With the launch of the third fund, Sony Ventures has more than \$500m under management. It has a 30-person team, who have mostly been recruited internally.

"The core force is from the internal teams," says Tsuchikawa. Given that one of the biggest challenges of any corporate venture team is to win the trust and acceptance of the parent company, building a team with company insiders is useful, he says.

Beyond that, building a team is about bringing in the right mix of skills between those who are good at networking with startups and those who are good at executing deals.

Around 40% of Sony Innovation Fund's portfolio companies have discussed some form of collaboration with Sony, Tsuchikawa says. But working together with Sony is not a prerequisite for doing a deal.

"We never force anything," Tsuchikawa says. Often it is the portfolio companies themselves that are keenest to pursue a joint project with the electronics and entertainment brand.

Sony continues to invest in early-stage companies through that first balance sheet-based fund. The second and third funds, however, have allowed it to take stakes in later-stage companies. "As time progressed, we felt the strong need and desire to get into more C, D and sometimes unicorn rounds," says Tsuchikawa.

The latest fund will focus on healthtech, fintech and entertainment. Entertainment is a natural focus for a brand, with a huge presence in music, movies and video games, while healthtech and fintech can build on this area of expertise – such as apps and games that can help with mental health. For example, earlier this year, Sony Ventures invested in Peppy, a digital platform for fertility and menopause-related healthcare advice.

Other recent investments by the fund include a stake in Lokal, an India-based local language social media application and a stake in Illumix, a Silicon Valley-based company creating Pokemon Go-style augmented reality experiences that could be used to make sports and music events more immersive for people. The team also invested in Waffle, a consumer insurtech company spun out of MIT, which helps people insure the virtual goods they have bought in online games.

Sony Ventures has scored a few good exits from the portfolio in recent years, including the IPO of carbon-neutral biofuels company Green Earth Institute and Japan's SmartCar, and the acquisition of live streaming platform Mobcrush by gaming company Super League. ■



Around 40% of Sony Innovation Fund's portfolio companies have discussed some form of collaboration with Sony. Often it is the portfolio companies themselves that are keenest to pursue a joint project

Martin Tschopp

CEO **Prosus Ventures**



The key is that we partner with businesses that are solving big societal needs with technology

Martin Tschopp was appointed chief executive of Prosus Ventures – Amsterdam-listed consumer internet group Prosus's corporate venture capital arm, and formerly known as Naspers Ventures – in November 2020 after nearly four years as a COO at the unit.

Talking to Global Corporate Venturing in 2021, Tschopp said: "The company has built a strong, global footprint and in the year ahead and beyond, Prosus Ventures will ensure we have a continuous flow of future growth opportunities in the wings.

"The key is that we partner with businesses that are solving big societal needs with technology, in a uniquely local way. We think about where we can really make an impact and zero-in on sectors of the economy where technology can lead to meaningful change in consumer behaviour and economics."

Over the course of the past year, Prosus Ventures has invested in a range of companies. It has taken a role as lead investor on the \$11m series A raise for Spendflo, a software-as-a-service buying and optimisation platform, and has participated in the \$26m series A round for India-based legal contract process specialist SpotDraft. The latter deal is part of a wider drive to increase the unit's business-to-business investment activity in the country.

Tschopp has spent the past two decades working in a variety of internet businesses around the world. Immediately prior to Prosus, he was CEO of Kiva.org, a non-profit offering access to capital to under-served communities. Before that, he spent many years as an operator leading ecommerce businesses ranging in size from small classifieds startups to large marketplaces such as eBay Germany. ■

Geert van de Wouw

Managing director **Shell Ventures**



Shell Ventures invests in early-stage companies that are developing innovative energy technologies

Geert van de Wouw has been managing director for Anglo-Dutch oil and gas supplier Shell's corporate venturing unit, Shell Ventures, for more than 11 years.

Originally launched in 1997, Shell Ventures invests in early-stage companies that are developing innovative energy technologies, as well as backing technology spinouts of Shell. The unit focuses on three key areas: oil and gas technologies, renewables and information technology.

The unit's recent investments include a lead role in the \$3m seed round for nanotube manufacturer DexMat, a part in the \$30m series C round for car-washing service Get Spiffy and participation in the \$15m series A raise for Chooose, developer of a digital platform for climate action management.

Prior to joining Shell Ventures, van de Wouw

served as Shell's eurozone economic turmoil response lead, helping to manage the economic crisis experienced by the energy supply chain sector in 2011 and 2012. He previously led the supplier management efforts for large enterprise suppliers on behalf of Shell, having joined the group in 2003 to oversee Shell Global Solutions' business development in Europe, Commonwealth of Independent States and Africa region.

Before joining Shell, van de Wouw was regional director for business development at engineering, construction and maintenance services company Fluor Corporation in Europe, the Middle East and Africa. He has a master's degree in molecular sciences from University of Wageningen in the Netherlands and received postgraduate education at IMD Business School in Switzerland. ■

Laura Veroneau

Managing partner **Optum Ventures**

Laura Veroneau is the managing partner and founding team member of Optum Ventures, the corporate venturing arm of pharmacy benefit manager Optum, which is part of UnitedHealth Group. The unit is an early-stage investment firm focused on emerging healthcare technology and analytics.

Veroneau manages Optum Ventures alongside Larry Renfro, who also works as vice chairman of UnitedHealth. She was promoted to managing partner in March 2022 having spent the previous five years as principal, senior principal and then, from January 2020, as partner.

She has led notable investments such as AbleTo, a US-based virtual healthcare developer that raised \$57.4m in a series A round in 2017, and US-based healthcare and social service network provider Unite Us, which raised \$195.6m.

Optum Ventures has invested more than \$600m since it was founded. Among its recent investments are a role in the \$75m series D raise for Cortica, provider of neurological therapies for children, participation in the \$13m series B round for virtual-reality therapy firm BehaVR and involvement in the £330m series E round for DispatchHealth, a provider of mobile and virtual healthcare in domestic settings.

Veroneau started her career running product development at a healthcare startup serving health plans, hospitals and employers before transitioning to the corporate strategy team at UnitedHealth Group. There, she focused on its innovation pipeline, which is mostly concentrated on emerging companies and international markets.

Veroneau also sits on the Board of Overseers for Brigham and Women's Hospital. ■



The unit is an early-stage investment firm focused on emerging healthcare technology and analytics

Murali Venkatesan

Head **Danaher Ventures**

Murali Venkatesan is a new entrant to the GCV Powerlist, mainly because Danaher Ventures has spent the past four years building its team and portfolio, and is only now beginning to go public. But this team of investment professionals and a sizeable active portfolio look like a force to be reckoned with.

Founded in 1984 by brothers Stephen and Mitchell Rales, Danaher is a US conglomerate, which has been turning itself into a impactful biotechnology, life sciences and diagnostics company, in part, through acquisitions that have made it the owner of brands such as Beckman Coulter, Cytiva, Leica Micro and Biosystems, IDT and Cepheid. But corporate venture also has a part to play in the transformation.

"Danaher Ventures has played an important role in Danaher's strategic transformation into a science and technology leader. Our commitment

to supporting early-stage, leading-edge innovators is foundational to our mission of applying the power of science and technology to materially impact patient lives and improve human health," says Venkatesan.

Venkatesan spent his early career building upon the Human Genome Project, filing 17 patents related to gene sequencing technology. At Illumina he worked on reducing the cost of gene sequencing by three orders of magnitude, which has helped transform molecular medicine.

The Danaher Ventures team includes Samuel Ngai, leading Danaher Ventures Asia; Alex De Winter; Stephanie Chow, who was formerly at pharmaceuticals company Roche; David Cruikshank, who was previously with Arch Venture Partners; and early-stage life sciences investor Charlie Purtell, who has been with Danaher since 2010. ■



Danaher Ventures has played an important role in Danaher's strategic transformation into a science and technology leader

Erin VanLanduit

►FEATUREDENTRY

Head of corporate ventures **Cargill**



Erin VanLanduit is the head of corporate ventures at global food and agriculture producer Cargill. VanLanduit began her stint at Cargill in 2021, leading its newly established corporate venturing unit, but she has spent nearly two decades working in the food and beverage industry.

VanLanduit entered the food and beverage sector in 2006 after transitioning from her first career as a field artillery officer in the US Army. Since then, she worked across a variety of roles including marketing, brand management, global innovation, M&A integration and corporate venture capital. Her career has spanned organisations including Kraft Foods, McCain Foods, SC Johnson and Tyson Ventures.

"This career path found me," says VanLanduit, "From working initially on the operator side of a corporation and running P&L businesses, I found that I had a passion for innovation and finding new and different ways to help businesses grow."

Cargill's investment unit has a global mandate, with a team spread across multiple continents, supporting dozens of investments all over the world. Establishing career paths for staff is an important retention tool, she says. "It is imperative to create really good professional development plans so that team members are getting the right experience and exposure that they need to grow into their roles," says VanLanduit.

"I expect the best from my staff, so providing them with exposure internally and externally is integral to our unit's success and providing them with the networking and knowledge to grow in their careers and continue flourishing within Cargill."

Cargill Ventures invests in companies that align with Cargill's long-term growth objectives across a variety of verticals such as foodtech, agtech, life sciences, IT and sustainability. Specific investment theses under each of these direct portfolio construction to best support strategic priorities for the organisation.

In response to evolving organisational strategy, Cargill Ventures has spent

significant time refining investment theses. This, says VanLanduit, has led to: "The right mix of investments to support a strategic vision for the organisation, while also looking deeper into how we better partner internally with our high-growth businesses."

Since its establishment as a centralised function a few years ago, Cargill Ventures has made a variety of investments across relevant sectors. In 2021, it invested in Bushel, a software developer for the agriculture industry, Aleph Farms, a cultivated protein company, and ReGrow, a carbon MRV technology platform. In 2022, there were further investment in startups, such as Cubiq Foods, a foodtech firm pursuing alternative fat solutions, Grão Direto, a digital commodities trading platform, and Flyability, an industrial drone tech developer.

VanLanduit says Cargill Ventures' status as a corporate venture capital firm has provided a competitive edge and ability to stay active compared with traditional venture capital firms.

"The market conditions at present continue to challenge startups," she says, "We have a tremendous opportunity as a strategic investor to add value to the growth-stage companies we invest in and, unlike VCs that have really pulled back on their investments recently, we are positioned to continue to invest in areas of interest and provide the necessary resources to our companies."

Cargill Ventures is an active member in the VC and CVC ecosystem. The group is a member of the GCV Leadership Society, and participant in ICEX, the information to knowledge exchange network for corporate venturers. VanLanduit is chair of the Global AgriFoodTech Advisory Council for GCV, as well as being involved in organisations that seek to increase investment activity local to Cargill's global headquarters in Minnesota. Increasing diversity in the field is also a focus of the group, through support of women in CVC events and initiatives focused on recruiting from and investing in under-represented racial and ethnic groups. ■



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Alfonso Villanueva

Head **PayPal Ventures**

Alfonso Villanueva has been senior vice president with responsibility for global corporate strategy for digital payments firm PayPal since 2015, during which time he has also been in charge of the company's corporate venture capital arm, PayPal Ventures.

The unit has a remit to invest for financial return in businesses which are at the forefront of innovation in fintech, commerce enablement, digital infrastructure, as well as in crypto and blockchain technologies.

PayPal Ventures' recent investments have included participation in the series B raise for Finanzguru, a Germany-based, artificial intelligence-powered finance assistant, and a role in the venture round for cybersecurity specialist Deep Instinct.

Among the unit's 12 exits are Cambridge Blockchain, which was acquired by

distributed ledger technology firm Blockchains Management in late 2020, as well as fintech firm Dosh, which was sold to Cardlytics in a \$257m deal in 2021. PayPal Ventures has made more than 80 investments and has a portfolio of almost 50 companies.

Before joining PayPal in 2015, Villanueva spent more than 15 years with McKinsey & Company, where he served as the managing partner for the firm's high-tech, media and telecom practices in Asia-Pacific. Earlier in his career, he was the chief innovation officer at Singaporean telecoms conglomerate SingTel, where he was responsible for strategy, investments and partnerships in the digital sector, as well as all areas related to growth and innovation.

Villanueva has an MBA from London Business School. ■



The unit has a remit to invest for financial return in businesses which are at the forefront of innovation in fintech

Stefan Williams

VP of corporate development **Snowflake Ventures**

Stefan Williams runs Snowflake Ventures, the corporate venture capital arm of US-based data analysis software firm Snowflake.

Snowflake Ventures was founded in 2020 with the aim of using investment as a way to accelerate and augment the growth and adoption of the Snowflake Data Cloud as a strategic platform. The unit invests directly from the Snowflake balance sheet rather than from a dedicated fund, and will invest anywhere from series A through to pre-IPO funding rounds. It writes cheques of between \$1m and \$20m.

At the time Snowflake Ventures was set up, Williams said: "Our aim is to foster innovation through investing in growth-stage companies that demonstrate a commitment to mobilising data, provide value to our customers and expand opportunities for the data cloud."

Snowflake Ventures was involved in one of

2022's most valuable corporate investment rounds when it participated in a \$1bn-plus raise for cloud cybersecurity software producer Securonix, alongside Capital One Ventures, Verizon Ventures and Wipro Ventures.

Other recent investments include taking part in the series A rounds for Samootha, a data collaboration platform, and journey-mapping service TheyDo.

Snowflake was itself a corporate venturing portfolio company, having been backed in multiple rounds by Capital One Ventures.

Before joining Snowflake in 2019, Williams was responsible for corporate ventures at enterprise software company ServiceNow, call centre software provider Genesys and in investment banking for adviser Martinwolf. He has a master's in finance from the Warwick Business School at the University of Warwick. ■



Our aim is to foster innovation through investing in growth-stage companies that demonstrate a commitment to mobilising data

Donald Wihardja

CEO MDI Ventures

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When MDI Ventures was founded in 2015, it operated as telecommunications firm Telkom Indonesia's corporate venture capital arm. Donald Wihardja took over as CEO in 2020 and since then the investment unit has evolved into more of a corporate VC firm.

"We like to call ourselves a strategic VC more than corporate venture capital," says Wihardja. "We are evolving from just taking money from Telkom to doing strategic venture capital funded by Biofarma, which is the pharmaceutical state-owned enterprise for Indonesia, and Pertamina, which is the oil and gas, mining and energy company for Indonesia, as well as a group of companies representing the state-owned agriculture industry."

The model is partly down to the corporate structure of Indonesia, where the largest businesses are state-owned enterprises (SOEs) and the government is keen for them to invest in the startup ecosystem. That has meant considerable growth for MDI which, having established itself as a local corporate venturing powerhouse, is getting requests to form more strategic funds.

"We are fielding a lot of requests from other SOEs to run their VC arm," says Wihardja. The firm already runs seven funds or fund partnerships with entities such as Netherlands-based venture firm Finch Capital and South Korea's KB Financial Group, the latter an example of how it has grown outwards.

"Telkom has been with us for seven years now, but we now have funds that are not only funded by Telkom but by other external, private investors," he says. "For example, our new fund is 40% Telkom and 60% from two banks, one from Indonesia and one from Korea."

MDI has accumulated a portfolio of more than 80 companies and it disclosed 12 deals in 2022. The firm targets startups that are either based in or have a significant part of their business in Indonesia, and its portfolio includes unicorns Mobile Premier League, Nium and Kredivo. Kredivo,

which offers credit services to unbanked customers in Indonesia and Vietnam, raised a \$270m series D funding round earlier this year, valuing it at \$1.6bn.

Recent investments include Good Doctor Technology, the Indonesian healthcare app company, and Legit Group, a cloud kitchen operator based in Indonesia. MDI has also been a backer of Privy, an Indonesian company that provides trusted digital identities and legally-binding signatures.

Wihardja held C-suite positions at contextual advertising network Sitti and digital payment companies Indomog and 2C2P, before spending nearly six years as a partner at venture firm Convergence Ventures. MDI invests throughout Southeast Asia and through to Korea, and local and international startups can leverage his experience on both sides of the fence in Indonesia's early-stage tech scene.

"Although I tell startups that if they get the opportunity to expand, please do so, sometimes I am wary when one of them expands regionally without completely conquering the Indonesian market and they are nowhere near conquering that full market," says Wihardja. "Maybe when you are (multibillion-dollar tech companies) Gojek or Traveloka, you have already conquered the market. But most of the players are just scratching the surface and are still at the beginning, and you need the focus."

The firm takes part in deals from pre-seed to late stage and also runs incubator and accelerator programmes in addition to an angel investment network. As its investment teams are siloed in each fund, it has been ramping up recruitment to support imminent growth plans that include the launch of an impact investment fund, as well as partner funds with three or four SOEs in areas such as biohealth, energy, agriculture and film.

"Building that platform for other state-owned enterprises is what we have to do," says Wihardja. "And building the platform so we can grow a more professional investment team is our job." ■



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